

A stack of four iPad Air tablets in silver, yellow, pink, and blue, with a fifth iPad Air in front showing a colorful abstract wallpaper, all resting on a silver laptop keyboard.



Govt. orders action on TNHB land redevelopment issues

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Registration Department has ordered the District Registrar of Central Chennai to take action according to the provisions of the Tamil Nadu Apartment Ownership Act to resolve the issues relating to the redevelopment of a large land parcel developed by the Tamil Nadu Housing Board (TNHB) and protect the rights of the low Income group (LIG) and middle income group (MIG) residents.

A section of the residents has alleged serious ir-



The present builder proposes to build nine massive towers with 28 floors in Anna Nagar.

regularities in the redevelopment tender process of the Golden Jubilee Chennai Flat Owners' Welfare Association and have sought an inquiry under Section 27 of the Tamil Nadu Apartment Ownership Act, 2022.

They have requested the State government's intervention to prevent land grabbing, pointing to the TNHB allocation of 11.91 acres of prime land in Anna Nagar for "LIG and MIG flats only, reflects the philosophy that ordinary people have every right to live in convenient homes built and sold by the TNHB at affordable rates."

The present builder proposes to construct nine massive towers of 28 floors, each with modern amenities, a resident said. This would turn the government land into an abode of the very rich, changing the

demography of the area and defeating the purpose of the TNHB earmarking land for the LIG and MIG, residents said.

They demanded that the TNHB be directed to take up joint ventures of all its earlier constructions so that the flat owners could have absolute confidence about the new builder who redevelops the apartments. They also requested the government to intervene and order an inquiry into the selection process, directing an official inquiry into the irregular selection of the unqualified developer by the Welfare Association,

and restrain the illegal collection of Form J consent forms for redevelopment.

Residents alleged that the new builder did not fulfill even a single tender criteria – that it was started only in 2023, had a capital of 10 lakh, and showed no profit in the last three years – and yet, it was offered a ₹1000-crore project.

The residents have demanded policy protection for TNHB land by formulation of guidelines to ensure that the redeveloped colonies retained their affordable character, rather than being converted into luxury gated communities.

Man held for snatching gold chain from passenger

CHENNAI: Commuters and a railway policeman chased and nabbed Manikandan, 29, of Tiruvavur, moments after he snatched a gold chain from a woman at Palavanthangal railway station. He was later arrested by the Government Railway Police.

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I, RAMESH SambathKumar, Residing at Shempark, Yuga Homes, Phase II, D.No.1-D, Nukkampalayam Link Road, Semmenchery, Sholinganallur, Chennai-600119 have changed the name of my minor son from Hridhay D.Ramesh to Hridhay Divya Ramesh vide Affidavit dated 04.08.2026 sworn before Notary at Chennai.

MY DAUGHTER, S Aadhira, born on 28th May 2010(District of Birth: Chennai), residing at No. 26, Balaji Nagar 1st Cross Street, Padialalur, Chennai-600 052 shall henceforth be known as S. SHRI AADHIRA, Chennai, 6th August 2026. R. SANATHOSH KUMAR(Father)

MY SON, M. Nithya Pooshan, born on 21st October 2009 (District of Birth: Chennai), residing at No. 24/2, 1st Street, Ramalinga Nagar Extension, Puzhithivakkam, Chennai-600 091, shall henceforth be known as NITHYAPOOSHAN M - M.MANIKANDAN (Father)

I,SRIDEVI RENGASAMY, Aadhar No. 466344647431,do hereby declare that I have changed the name of my son from Sujan Sriram to Sujan Sriram Sundararajan,vide affidavit dt 12/06/26

I, hitherto known as Jhantu Malakar son of Jiten Malakar, resident of Plot No. 2, Sai Enclave, S1, 2nd Floor, 10th Street Extension, Soumya Nagar, Opposite Nest Fantasy, Perumbakkam, P.O. Medavakkam, Chengalpattu, Tamil Nadu - 600100, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Vivek Malakar.

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In accordance with the Hon'ble High Court of Madras orders Rev.Appln. No.116 of 2023 and CMP No.13750 of 2023 in OSA No.17 of 2022 dated 30.07.2026, the draft voters' list for the Graduate's Constituency of Pachaiyappa's Trust Board election to three members has been published today, 07.08.2026, on the Pachaiyappa's Trust Board's website www.pachaiyappastrust.org as detailed below:

Category	Details
Category No. 1	Non-updated old voters' list - Total: 3,284 voters
Category No. 2	Number of Applications received based on the newspaper announcement made by Hon'ble Justices P.Shanmugam S. Jagadeesan and V.Parthiban - Total : 1,387
Category No. 3	New Applications received after 24.06.2026 before 08.07.2026, pursuant to the Madras High Court order dated 17.06.2026 - Total: 154

The voters listed in the aforementioned graduate constituency are requested to verify the portal and submit the relevant documents for scrutiny and objections if any found, to the Pachaiyappa's Trust Board Office either in person or through the e-mail ID : ptbelection2026@gmail.com on or before 14.08.2026, 5:00 PM.

New applications for inclusion in the graduate constituency shall not be accepted.

In accordance with the order of the Honorable Madras High Court, the voters are eligible to vote not more than one constituency out of the available constituencies. Therefore, voters who have multiple votes should opt their choice of Constituency for casting their vote and communicate it to the Pachaiyappa's Trust Board Office either in person or through email ID : ptbelection2026@gmail.com on or before 14.08.2026 5:00 PM.

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Commuters demand lift, parking space at railway station in Gummidipoondi

They complain about the slow progress of its renovation under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme. They also seek adequate passenger amenities and an increase in the speed limit on the loop line

TRACK TALES
R. Srikanth
CHENNAI

Commuters have complained about the slow progress of the renovation of the Gummidipoondi railway station under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme. While they welcome the station's inclusion in the redevelopment project after years of neglect, they criticise railway officials for failing to provide adequate passenger amenities at the station.

S. Suresh Babu, president of Gummidipoondi Railway Passengers' Welfare Association, said that though lifts had been installed on all platforms, the absence of one on the Bazaar Road side of the station made it difficult for senior citizens and women to access Platform 1, where



Easier access: Commuters demand halts for long-distance trains at Gummidipoondi railway station, as they currently have to travel to the Dr. MGR Central Railway Station to board them. FILE PHOTO

the suburban trains are operated from.

While appreciating the creation of a big parking space on the Bazaar road side, commuters point out the lack of parking facilities on the Bypass Road side, where the Gummidipoondi SIPCOT complex is located.

R. Ponambalavanan, of Peddikuppam, want work on the third and fourth lines to be expedited. Commuters also seek the extension of the platform shelter on Platform 3, as the rear four coaches of the Circar Express remained outside its covered area, and an increase in the speed limit on

the loop line from 15 kmph to 30 kmph.

Stating that the Gummidipoondi railway station was becoming a key transport hub, they demanded stoppage for long-distance trains, as they currently had to travel to Dr. MGR Central station to board them.

4 persons arrested for taking away car after assaulting its driver

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Four persons were arrested for allegedly waylaying a car near St. Thomas Mount, assaulting its driver, and fleeing with the vehicle on Wednesday.

The arrested persons were identified as Karthik, 41, of Sriperumbudur; Shankar, 51, of Nandambakam; Prasad, 40, of St. Thomas Mount; and Prasad's younger brother Ramachandran, 38.

According to the police, Abikash, 21, of Anna Nagar, was asked by his uncle Meganathan, who runs a car mechanic shop in Kolathur, to return a BMW to its owner near the Nanganallur Metro station after completing the repairs.

While Abikash was driving the car near Nanganallur on Tuesday night, four men allegedly intercepted the vehicle, abused and as-

saulted him, before forcing him out of the car. They then fled in the BMW and the car they arrived in.

Based on Abikash's complaint, the St. Thomas Mount police registered a case and launched an investigation.

A team from the station's crime wing traced and arrested the four suspects on Wednesday.

The police said the BMW was recovered and a car used by the suspects, along with four mobile phones, were seized.

During interrogation, the police found that Karthik ran a used-car dealership and had a financial dispute with the owner of the BMW. They suspect that Karthik and his associates took the car following the dispute.

The four accused were produced before a court and remanded in judicial custody.

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Chennai Airport Tomorrow

35°C

Morning will be comfortable. Day will be warm. Spell of light to moderate rain and thundershower to occur.

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Minjur desalination plant to be partially operational soon

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai Metrowater is set to begin partial operations of the Minjur desalination plant, the city's first desalination plant, in about two months. While the plant has a capacity to treat 100 million litres of seawater a day (mld), the water agency plans to initially produce 20 mld to boost water supply in north Chennai.

The plant ceased operations in November 2024 due to issues at the company operating the facility, following which its contract was terminated.

A press release said that

once the detailed project report is prepared by the Tamil Nadu Water Investment Company Limited, efforts would be taken to operate the plant to its full capacity. Metrowater Managing Director T. Anand, who inspected the plant, instructed the officials to expedite the works.

The partial operations would augment water supply in areas falling under Tiruvottiyur, Manali, and Madhavaram zones. Work is in progress to clean the intake sump and other infrastructure to draw seawater. Moreover, reverse osmosis membranes are also being removed.

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INBRIEF



DMK MLAs protest as Minister digresses from Budget speech

A brief commotion occurred in the Assembly on Thursday when Agriculture Minister R. Vinoth, after completing his Budget speech, began making comments that digressed from the printed text. DMK MLAs objected to it. However, the Minister continued to speak. Once he finished his speech, DMK MLAs demanded that the Minister not be allowed to speak about anything other than the Budget, and insisted that the statements that digressed from the topic be expunged from the Assembly records. However, Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar said only those statements that strictly required removal would be expunged.

CM to hold consultation with T.N. MPs on delimitation Bill

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay will consult the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs from Tamil Nadu on the delimitation Bill proposed by the Union government. According to an official release, the Centre has been taking steps to pass the Bill in Parliament. The Chief Minister will hold a meeting with Tamil Nadu MPs from both Houses of Parliament at Kalaivanar Arangam in Chennai on August 8 to discuss the impact the Bill would have on the State. The invitations for the consultative meeting are being sent to the MPs through the Tamil Nadu House in New Delhi, the release said.

Budget is far-sighted and offers hope, says Vijay; no real relief to drought-hit delta farmers: Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday said the Revised Budget Estimates, with its far-sighted vision, had instilled hope in students, youth, women, children, persons with disabilities, transpersons, workers, fishermen, weavers, entrepreneurs, government employees, and other sections of society. In a post on social media, the Chief Minister congratulated Finance Minister N. Marie Wilson and Agriculture Minister R. Vinoth for presenting what he described as forward-looking Budgets. Mr. Vijay said the Agriculture Budget not only contained measures to strengthen the farm sector, but also laid emphasis on

the development of allied sectors such as fisheries, dairy development, food processing, and value addition. DMK president M.K. Stalin dismissed the Agriculture Budget as an “empty” document, alleging that it had failed to provide any meaningful relief to farmers in the Cauvery delta region. In a post on social media, Mr. Stalin said that instead of addressing the drought situation and the distress faced by farmers, the Budget had merely heaped praise on the Chief Minister. Questioning the government’s approach, Mr. Stalin asked whether it believed its responsibility ended at merely renaming welfare schemes introduced by the previous



C. Joseph Vijay

DMK government with the prefix ‘Vetri’. He said the DMK would raise farmers’ issues throughout the Budget session and press the government to take corrective measures. ‘No significant scheme’ AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami criticised the first Agricul-

ture Budget for not containing “any significant scheme”. Addressing journalists outside the Assembly chamber, Mr. Palaniswami listed a number of electoral promises of the ruling party, and contended that none of them had been fulfilled. On the issue of a crop loan waiver, the AIADMK leader accused the TVK of having “misled” the farmers, as the Chief Minister’s announcement on the relief to the agriculturists was “different” from what his party had promised in the run-up to the Assembly election. Though Gen Z had high hopes of the TVK-led government’s Budget, they were left disappointed, BJP State unit president Nainar Nagenthiran said, terming

the Budget ‘zero’. Addressing a press conference in Chennai, Mr. Nagenthiran said that though many assurances were made before the elections, there were no relevant announcements in the Budget. Only the existing welfare programmes had been renamed, he said. Assurances were made that financial aid for women would be increased to ₹2,500, free rides would be offered in all buses for women, and six gas cylinders would be provided per year, but there were no announcements in this regard, he said. Assurances regarding insurance cover for gig workers did not figure among the Budget announcements, he said. There were no announcements for the MSME sector, he said.

CM urges PM to expedite linking of Godavari, Cauvery, Gundar

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to expedite the implementation of the Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar river linking project. He has also proposed the setting up of a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) for the initiative. In a letter to Mr. Modi, the Chief Minister said the Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar link project was a crucial long-term opportunity to augment Tamil Nadu’s surface water resources. He said the project was vital for addressing the growing drinking water and irrigation needs of the people of Tamil Nadu, particularly those in the southern districts. Pointing out that the National Water Development Agency (NWDA) had prepared a Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the

The project is vital for addressing the growing drinking water and irrigation needs of the people of Tamil Nadu, particularly those in the southern districts. Godavari-Pennar-Palar-Vellar link as the first phase, the Chief Minister said this proposed alignment terminates a few kilometres short of the Cauvery River. National importance The Chief Minister requested that priority be given instead to the Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar river linking project which, he said, was of national importance. To ensure fast-track execution, Mr. Vijay urged

the Union government to grant the initiative ‘National Project’ status. The Chief Minister also suggested the creation of a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV), involving the participation of the Central government and the relevant States, to complete the project within a set timeframe. Furthermore, he requested the Prime Minister to issue appropriate directives regarding this matter to the NWDA and the Ministry of Jal Shakti. In a separate letter to Minister for External Affairs S. Jaishankar, the Chief Minister flagged the arrest of 11 Indian fishermen from Ramanathapuram by the Sri Lankan Navy, and sought his intervention to get them released. He also called for early revival of bilateral dialogue through the Joint Working Group (JWG) to address these recurring arrests.

Senior AIADMK rebel MLAs meet Water Resources Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Rebel legislators of the AIADMK on Thursday met Water Resources and Rural Development Minister N. Anand at the Secretariat. Senior leaders S.P. Velumani, C.Ve. Shanmugam, and K.P. Anbalagan were among those who met the Minister. Mr. Velumani told reporters that he met the Minister to include certain areas, falling under his constituency of Thondamuthur, in the Athikadavu-Avinashi water supply project. ‘Not joining TVK’ When asked whether he would join the TVK, Mr. Velumani strongly rebutted the suggestion and said the question did not arise as, after all, it was the AIADMK that had “raised”

him and others politically. He lauded the TVK-led regime for reviving certain schemes that were in force when the AIADMK was in power, and were scrapped by the previous DMK government. He pointed out that the government should be given time to prove its mettle. Mr. Shanmugam said he had constituency-related issues to raise with the Minister. When asked why he did not attend the consultation held by AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, he said, “Why should I meet him?”

Non-bailable warrant issued against ex-Minister Ponmudy

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A city court has issued a non-bailable warrant against former Minister and DMK leader K. Ponmudy, directing the police to arrest him and produce him before the court on September 2, after he failed to appear for the trial proceedings in a case registered against him for allegedly giving a speech that promoted hatred against the Hindu religion. The case was registered following a complaint by BJP councillor Uma Anandan. The complainant alleged that a speech delivered by Mr. Ponmudy on April 6, 2025, promoted hatred against the Hindu religion and hurt religious sentiments. Though the speech was delivered at a closed-door event, it was later uploaded on YouTube and other social media platforms. Mr. Ponmudy delivered



K. Ponmudy

the speech at the DMK Youth Wing office in Chennai, and reportedly spoke about Saivism and Vaishnavism. Following the controversy over his remarks, the DMK removed him from the post of deputy general secretary of the party on April 11, 2025. Mr. Ponmudy was booked under Sections 196 (1)(a) (promoting disharmony, enmity or hatred on religious grounds), 299 (deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings), and 302 (uttering words or making gestures with deliberate in-

He failed to appear for trial proceedings in a case registered against him for allegedly promoting hatred against the Hindu religion tent to wound religious feelings) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The case is pending before the III Metropolitan Magistrate Court in George Town. When the matter came up for hearing before Magistrate C. Sundarapandian at the George Town court on Thursday, a petition was filed on behalf of Mr. Ponmudy, seeking exemption from personal appearance. The court dismissed the plea. As Mr. Ponmudy had failed to appear for the hearings, the court issued a non-bailable warrant and directed the police to arrest him and produce him before the court on or before September 2.

T.N. govt. announces price support scheme for tomatoes, onions

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government, in its Agriculture Budget tabled on Thursday, proposed a price support scheme for tomatoes and onions to bring relief to farmers during a price crash, while also placing a thrust on green manure crops for improving soil fertility and reducing dependence on fertilizers. The price support scheme will be similar to the Market Intervention Scheme (MIS) of the Union government for mangoes, P. Shankar, Agriculture Secretary and Agriculture Production Commissioner, told reporters on Thursday. While the modalities for the implementation of the scheme were still being worked out, the experience with the MIS for mangoes would be put to use for this, Dr. Shankar added. In the case of mangoes, which have a Union government-supported scheme, pulp factories are notified as temporary regulatory markets for a couple of months during the season, he said, adding that transactions are done in the presence of officials from the Horticulture and Revenue Departments.



Agriculture Secretary P. Shankar at a press meeting on Thursday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

“We are working out whether the government would purchase the crop outright or facilitate sale while paying for the difference between the production cost and the market price,” he said. A Market Intervention Scheme - Price Stabilisation Revolving Fund (MIS-PSRF) will be created by the Tamil Nadu State Agricultural Marketing Board with a State fund of ₹4.26 crore to protect farmers from a price crash of perishables such as tomatoes and onions. The government has allocated ₹63.5 crore to improve soil fertility through green manure plantations. Seeds of Sunn Hemp, Daincha, and Kolinji plants will be distributed to farmers to sow one lakh acres of land, while another 22,000 acres will be covered by multi-grain crop seeds.

Orange alert issued for 8 districts in Kerala today

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The flash-flood-affected regions in Kerala experienced intensified rainfall on Thursday, influenced by the combined effect of cyclonic circulations over the Bay of Bengal.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued an orange alert, warning of very heavy rainfall, in Pathanamthitta, Idukki, Kottayam, Malappuram, Kozhikode, Wayanad, Kan-nur and Kasaragod districts on Friday.

Yellow alert

The remaining six districts of the State have been put on yellow alert, where isolated heavy rain is expected.

According to a weather bulletin issued by the Meteorological Department on Thursday, an upper air cyclonic circulation lies over the southeast Bay of Bengal and another upper air cyclonic circulation persists over the northwest Bay of Bengal and adjoining north Odisha-Gangetic West Bengal coasts.

Under the combined effect of the systems, moderate heavy rainfall is likely, mainly in the hilly regions of the State for the next two days.

Highest rainfall

Meanwhile, the Ayyankunnu region in Kannur recorded the highest rainfall of 56 mm until 5.30 p.m. on Thursday, followed by Vaikkom with 54.5 mm and Koothattukulam with 40 mm.

Kerala set to launch project to improve police-citizen ties

'My Police Station' aims at making police force accessible and accountable; the responsibility of Station House Officers will be entrusted to sub-inspectors, says Home Minister Chennithala

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Kerala's police system and police stations will undergo a major transformation starting August 15, with the launch of a new initiative titled "My Police Station", which is aimed at making the police force more accessible and accountable to the public, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said at a press conference here on Thursday.

Calling it a historic reformation of the Kerala Police, Mr. Chennithala said the new initiative was a decisive step towards democratic policing that delivers better service to citizens.



Sub-inspectors will take charge as SHOs in 419 stations out of the State's 484 law-and-order police stations. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

Another key objective would be to completely eliminate custodial crimes, including custodial deaths and custodial violence.

From August 15, the responsibility of Station House Officers (SHOs) will be entrusted to sub-inspec-

tors. This is a reversal of the previous government's decision to appoint Circle Inspectors to the posts.

Strategic placements

The Minister said that this change would give young male and female officers

directly recruited to the posts of SIs, a greater sense of responsibility and sharpen their efficiency and decision-making abilities, he added.

Sub-inspectors will take charge as SHOs in 419 stations out of the State's 484 law-and-order police stations. Notably, women sub-inspectors will become SHOs in 63 police stations across the State.

In 64 stations of strategic significance, police officials in the rank of Circle Inspectors will continue to serve as SHOs.

Given the strategic importance of the Mullaperiyar dam, the SHO post at that station will remain with a Deputy Superintendent of Police (DySP).

Karnataka holds talks with Anthropic on AI

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Thursday held discussions with a delegation from Anthropic on forging a long-term partnership to accelerate the adoption of artificial intelligence across governance, higher education, healthcare, research and the State's startup ecosystem.

The meeting focused on

deploying applied AI solutions for both government and enterprise use cases, with an emphasis on "beneficial deployment" of AI while ensuring responsible use, data privacy and data sovereignty.

Discussions also covered the introduction of AI-focused certification programmes, including Claude certification and the use of AI in healthcare and life sciences, including AI for scientific research.

'Raise income cap for tribals' scholarships'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Kerala government has demanded that the Centre enhance the family income ceiling from ₹2.5 lakh to ₹4.5 lakh-₹5 lakh for availing post-metric scholarships by tribal students.

In a memorandum submitted to Union Tribal Affairs Minister Jual Oram, Kerala Minister for Welfare of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Back-

wards Classes K.A. Thulasi said the change in the ceiling was necessary, given the rising living costs.

The State said in the memorandum that the Centre might consider revising the implementation guidelines for the Grants-in-Aid under Article 275(i) of the Constitution to provide flexibility in the prescribed project period, particularly for infrastructure works executed in remote tribal areas.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.45 HRS)

Forecast for Friday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Rajasthan, Delhi, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Assam, Mizoram, Tripura, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala, Lakshadweep and Andaman & Nicobar Islands

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	15.8	30.3	26.0	Kurnool	2.8	32.5	25.2
Ahmedabad	2.2	33.6	26.4	Lucknow	14	30.2	25.6
Aizawl	73.4	27.8	20.6	Madurai	—	36.5	27.1
Bengaluru	1.2	29.0	21.0	Mangaluru	7.2	29.6	24.9
Bhopal	0.6	30.6	24.0	Mumbai	9	31.5	25.5
Bhubaneswar	16.1	32.6	23.8	Mysuru	—	29.0	20.2
Chandigarh	—	31.4	25.0	New Delhi	56	27.6	25.6
Chennai	—	35.4	26.6	Patna	3.8	33.5	26.3
Coimbatore	—	32.4	22.4	Port Blair	24.9	29.1	24.8
Dehradun	42.1	25.8	22.5	Prayagraj	30.3	27.4	24.4
Gangtok	19	23.3	17.9	Puducherry	—	34.9	27.7
Goa	7	30.2	25.7	Pune	9.5	27.5	22.0
Guwahati	0.8	36.0	26.3	Raipur	3.5	32.7	25.6
Hubballi	—	27.0	22.0	Ranchi	36	29.2	23.0
Hyderabad	0.8	30.8	24.1	Shillong	0.9	25.6	17.0
Imphal	1	28.7	23.5	Shimla	4.6	22.4	17.0
Jaipur	—	31.2	27.0	Shrinagar	—	30	19.4
Kochi	34	27.0	24.4	Thiruvananthapuram	1.2	29.0	24.4
Kohima	—	26.0	19.0	Tiruchirappalli	—	36.9	28.4
Kolkata	49.2	30.1	26.6	Vijayawada	44	33.4	25.2
Kozhikode	5.4	31.2	25.0	Visakhapatnam	7	34.5	27.7

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	20	29	60	61	82	■	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Bhiwani
Bengaluru	20	27	46	31	69	■	Haryana recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 159
Chennai	5	9	37	13	118	■	indicating a moderate level of pollution. In contrast, Madikeri, Karnataka recorded a healthy AQI score of 14
Delhi	19	39	99	136	138	■	
Hyderabad	12	11	39	35	59	■	
Kolkata	16	26	31	79	95	■	
Lucknow	35	12	25	40	117	■	
Mumbai	3	14	17	105	94	■	
Pune	20	19	68	36	47	■	
Visakhapatnam	5	59	16	38	93	■	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

INBRIEF



Revanth to unveil distribution of laminated ration cards

The Telangana government would launch the distribution of 1.05 crore laminated Public Distribution System Ration Cards on August 15, 2026, on the occasion of Independence Day. Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy would formally commence the distribution in Sangareddy and it will be simultaneously rolled out in 119 Assembly constituencies. The old cards will be replaced with the new ones containing a number and QR code, which can be used to fetch details of the beneficiaries online.

AI-powered digital crop survey launched in Karnataka

The Karnataka government on Thursday announced the launch of a Composite Digital Crop Survey (CDCS), which will be implemented on a pilot basis in five selected *hoblis* (village clusters) within the State. Karnataka has been implementing the Digital Crop Survey since 2018 using a mobile app to collect plot-level crop data. To further enhance the accuracy and scientific validation of this data, the CDCS model has now been developed by integrating cutting-edge technologies into the existing crop survey framework, said a release from the government.

3 from Gujarat held for theft of idol from Karnataka temple

The Vijayapura police have arrested three persons from Gujarat in connection with the theft of a 32-kg silver idol from the Sri Pavada Basaveshwara Temple at Basarakod village in Karnataka, recovering stolen property and other articles worth ₹52.7 lakh. Superintendent of Police of Vijayapura district Laxman Nimbaragi said that the incident was reported on July 6 after unidentified persons allegedly broke open the locks of two iron doors of the temple and entered the sanctum sanctorum. Mr. Nimbaragi said that the accused were remanded in judicial custody.

Hero stone found in Karnataka sheds light on last day of Hoysala dynasty ruler

Sathish G.T.
SHIVAMOGGA

The villagers in Neeragunda in Arsikere taluk of Karnataka have stumbled upon a centuries-old *veeragallu* (hero stone) bearing a Kannada inscription that could resolve the long-standing confusion over the date of the death of Vishnuvardhana, the ruler of the Hoysala dynasty.

The village has two Hoysala-era temples – Malleshwara and Lakshmi Narayana Swamy. The latter had fallen into a dilapidated state, prompting residents to undertake its restoration and raise funds for the



The *veeragallu* found at Neeragunda in Arsikere taluk refers to the death of Hoysala ruler Vishnuvardhana. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

same. Hoysala is the prominent dynasty that ruled many parts of today's Karnataka and Tamil Nadu between the 11th and the 14th centuries.

While workers were en-

gaged in foundation work on June 28, they unearthed two stone slabs bearing sculptural work, which were later brought to the notice of researchers.

Shashidhar H.G., who

has documented over 600 Hoysala temples so far, visited the site and identified the two slabs as *veeragallus*, one of which carried a significant inscription. *Veeragallus* are memorial stones placed in honour of warriors.

"Going by the text, one can say it is a *veeragallu* installed in memory of a soldier, who sacrificed his life soon after Vishnuvardhana's death at Bankapura. The date mentioned in the inscription corresponds to December 11, 1141, as per the Gregorian calendar," he said. Vishnuvardhana is believed to have died at Bankapura.

NIA arrests another accused in Karnataka BJP activist's murder

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has arrested another absconding accused in the 2022 murder of Karnataka BJP activist Praveen Nettaru, taking the total number of arrests in the case to 25.

The accused, Ummar Farook M.R., was arrested in Kochi, Kerala. He had been absconding since the investigation began. He was wanted under a Red Corner Notice (RCN) and a non-bailable warrant. The NIA had announced a ₹4 lakh reward for information leading to his arrest.

Investigators believe that he had attended a meeting in the office of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI) in Sullia before

the murder.

The agency said its investigation found that the accused agreed to provide his motorcycle to a co-accused for reconnaissance and identification of targets in Bellare village in Karnataka, ahead of the killing. He is also accused of participating in an attempt to eliminate a protected witness in the case.

Praveen Nettaru was murdered on July 26, 2022, triggering widespread outrage across Karnataka. The NIA, which later took over the probe, has maintained that the murder was part of a larger criminal conspiracy allegedly orchestrated by the banned PFI.

The NIA said two accused are still absconding, and efforts are under way to arrest them.

A.P. CM hits out at YSRCP president ahead of local polls

G.V.R. Subba Rao
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh politics witnessed another sharp escalation on Thursday as Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu hit out at YSRCP president Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, stating that it would take him "just two minutes" to bring "Jagan and his company" under control.

The remarks, made during a marathon Cabinet meeting at the State Secretariat in Amaravati, underscored the ruling alliance's increasingly aggressive political strategy ahead of local body elections. Beyond a routine administrative review, the meeting took on a political dimension, with discussions centered on responding to the YSRCP on multiple fronts.

Mr. Naidu accused the Opposition of spreading misinformation on the Mega DSC recruitment process and directed Ministers to counter what he described as a sustained propaganda. He reportedly said that several Opposition leaders were engaging in unlawful activities and asserted that the government possessed sufficient evidence to expose them.

Odisha State Medical Corporation Limited (OSMCL)
In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-II, Bhubaneswar-751001
Tel.:(0674) 2380608; Website: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in>;
Email: proc.osmcl.od@od.gov.in

Notification No. 7425/OSMCL/2026

Date : 05.08.2026

NOTICE INVITING Re-Tender for SUPPLY, INSTALLATION & COMMISSIONING OF MULTIPARA PATIENT MONITOR (5-PARA) EQUIPMENT ON CONTRACT BASIS

Online Bids through e-Tender portal (<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>) are invited from eligible bidders for supply, Installation & commissioning of Equipment as per the particulars mentioned below:

Sl. No.	Bid Reference No.	Item Name	Bid Document Cost inclusive of GST (Rs.)
1.	OSMCL/2026-27/MONITOR_5 Para/03	Re-tender for Supply, Installation & Commissioning of Multipara Patient Monitor (5-Para) Equipment on Contract Basis	Rs. 5,900/-

Sl. No.	Particulars	Date and time
1.	Date & time of release of bid	05/08/2026, 5 PM
2.	Date & time of Pre-Bid Meeting	12/08/2026, 11.30 AM Venue : Conference Hall, Odisha State Medical Corporation Ltd., In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-II, Bhubaneswar
3.	Date & time of Online bid submission	Start Date & Time End Date & Time 19/08/2026, 3 PM 08/09/2026, 5 PM
4.	Date & time for submission of Tender Documents, Tender Document Fee and EMD amount as per Clause No.3.1 and 6.17 of tender document	Start Date & Time End Date & Time 09/09/2026, 10 AM 18/09/2026, 2.30 PM
5.	Date & time of Online Technical bid Opening	18/09/2026, 3 PM
6.	Date of opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> and <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof.

Managing Director, OSMCL
10001/442/2627
OIPR-10001/0112/126-27/0009



Stop the scam

The digital arrest scam persists from overseas actors

The Supreme Court of India’s order of August 4 on the “digital arrest” menace is notable for not being lured into complacency. After all, the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre’s status report showed that complaints on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal fell from 1,23,672 in 2024 to 58,249 in 2025, and stood at 16,377 in the first six months of 2026. The Court called the figures “certainly encouraging” and directed the Reserve Bank of India to circulate a standard operating procedure for temporary debit holds on mule accounts, States to notify cybercrime coordination centres and operationalise e-Zero FIRs, and an inter-departmental committee to examine a victim compensation framework. Thanks to advisories from banks, telecom operators and the police, fewer senior citizens and others are getting victimised by these scams, which have succeeded due to older victims’ deference to authority and fear of legal trouble. Yet, scammers find it easy to target youth and professionals, and senior citizens the advisories have not reached. And there have been very few convictions despite scrutiny and investigation, which suggests that law enforcement must move faster in tackling these scams.

The digital scammers have proved nimble in their *modus operandi*. They route calls through SIM boxes to mask their origin, making them appear as Indian numbers, and use multiple mule accounts across many States to move funds swiftly. They are now known to deploy deepfakes on video calls to dupe victims and remain untraceable by investigators. In effect, the fraudsters always seem to be a step ahead of those pursuing them. The Court’s insistence on restoring money – completed in 36,290 cases involving ₹18.05 crore – and on the swift disposing of account-freeze cases, alongside detection systems such as MuleHunter.AI, used in over 20 banks, will help limit the damage even when perpetrators are not caught or convicted. But convictions are rare as many of these fraud and extortion schemes are run from overseas “scam compounds” in Myanmar, the wider Golden Triangle, and Cambodia. In Myanmar, scam centres proliferated through direct and indirect official patronage, even as recent scrutiny produced raids that were largely for show with these centres shifting to new areas in the conflict-ridden country. After Beijing’s crack-down, in 2023, on scam centres targeting Chinese victims, scammers shifted focus to other countries, with Indians also being trafficked and tortured to commit digital crimes against fellow citizens. New Delhi must use diplomatic pressure in coordination with China, the U.S. and ASEAN to compel Naypyidaw and Phnom Penh to act against the networks that host these compounds.

Access paradox

Private medical education widens access, but affects affordability

The scope of medical education in India has expanded so rapidly that it raises important questions about access to it. The number of seats has nearly tripled in 12 years, thanks in part to the government’s push to improve access to health care, entailing infrastructure upgrades and simplified regulations. However, much of the growth has been happening in the private sector, in addition to new government colleges attached to district hospitals. This year, for the first time, private institutions host more than half of all MBBS seats. Of the roughly 10,000 new seats, 79% are in such institutions, a sign that growth in the near future will remain concentrated thus. The increase in seats is, in and of itself, commendable as India’s students still compete fiercely for MBBS seats even as health-care centres suffer a debilitating shortage of specialist practitioners. Thousands of students also seek education abroad. Therefore, expanding domestic ‘capacity’ is a natural response and the rising number of seats ought to relieve the bottleneck and keep talent at home.

But problems abound. Whereas an MBBS seat in a government college rarely exceeds ₹5 lakh for the full term, that in a private institution can cost 10 times more, sustained in part by the unflagging demand for health care. These institutions’ commercial viability is clustered in specific geographies, especially in tier-I and -II cities in the more prosperous States, where incomes are higher. Unless their students deliberately fan out after graduation, their skills also become concentrated in these clusters, whereas the paucity of health-care providers is felt more keenly in the rural areas farther away. Rapid growth also raises the risk of highly uneven quality, with institutions seeking to secure NMC accreditation with the bare minimum of facilities rather than mindfully addressing local needs. ‘Capitation fees’, which persist despite government bans, create new debt that can influence behaviour after graduation. Finally, sans competitive salaries, housing and schools, and assured career progression, graduates gravitate to private practice or abroad. Paradoxically, then, the surge in private capacity obligates the government to keep adding capacity, including opening new AIIMS-like institutions, so the number of cheap seats also keeps increasing. The NMC’s rule of having half of all private institution seats be charged at government rates should be enforced; the NMC should also embrace mechanisms that support surprise inspections and the ability to inspect records without institutions’ permission. Finally, beyond compelling rural service, governments should reward it, in addition to ensuring that the daily needs of rural health-care workers and their families and of hospitals are both well-met.

“When we are finished, take over your government. It will be yours to take. This will be probably your only chance for generations,” United States President Donald Trump told Iranians on February 28, 2026, after the U.S. and Israel assassinated Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and launched a war against the country. More than five months later, the war that Mr. Trump believed would be over in weeks, if not days, is far from over. The Islamic Republic has not only survived but has also consolidated its position, at home and in the region. Mr. Trump has alternated between strikes, ceasefires, talks, threats, ultimatums, renewed strikes, and U-turns in an attempt to shape the course and outcome of the conflict and the behaviour of the Iranian state, while seeking a face-saving exit. But with the war unresolved and his objectives unmet, Mr. Trump, confronting a resolute yet risk-tolerant Tehran, has found himself in a strategic cul-de-sac.

The U.S. and Israel launched the war with four principal objectives: destroy Iran’s nuclear programme; dismantle its missile capabilities and military industrial base; end Tehran’s support for its non-state quartet (Hamas, Houthis, Hezbollah and Hashad) and bring about a regime change. The first three objectives, however, were inseparable from the fourth. Without toppling the Islamic Republic, achieving any of the other goals appeared impossible even before the war began. This makes regime change or regime collapse the central strategic aim of the war on which all the others depended.

The President’s grave miscalculation

The challenge before Mr. Trump was to engineer regime change through an aerial campaign alone. He was unwilling to commit ground troops, and the U.S. lacked a credible local ally capable of leading an armed insurgency against Tehran. Mr. Trump initially seemed aware of the risks of attacking Iran. In June 2025, the U.S. joined Israel in striking Iran’s nuclear facilities but quickly stepped back. He then declared that he had “obliterated” Iran’s nuclear programme and compelled Israel to accept a ceasefire. Determined to avoid a wider regional conflict, he sought to prevent the war from spiralling out of control.

But by February 2026, two developments, along with sustained pressure from Israel, appeared to have convinced him that Iran could be defeated in a short war. The first was the U.S. invasion of Venezuela in early January, which in Mr. Trump’s view was a resounding success. U.S. forces abducted President Nicolás Maduro, and withdrew without suffering casualties. Venezuelan Vice-President Delcy Rodríguez, who assumed the acting presidency, quickly offered full cooperation with Washington. The second was the wave of violent protests and riots across



Stanly Johny

Iran in January, which reinforced the belief in Washington and Tel Aviv that the government in Tehran had been fatally weakened. They believed that by bombing Iran and decapitating its leadership, the regime would either collapse or result in a new leadership willing to cooperate with Washington, much as they believed had happened in Venezuela. This proved to be a grave miscalculation.

The three pillars of Iran’s response

Iran’s response rested on three pillars – preserving the state; regionalising the war; and enhancing its economic cost through horizontal escalation. Tehran understood that because Mr. Trump’s other war aims were dependent on regime change, preserving the Islamic Republic would, by itself, deny Washington its broader objectives. Mr. Trump mistook Iran for a personality-driven authoritarian regime, which could crumble once the head was taken out. But the Iranian state is sustained by a deeply-entrenched institutional system and an ideology that fuses Shia notions of sacrifice with the ideals of political revolution. Under attack, the state – designed and built to withstand both internal and external shocks – consolidated, while millions rallied around the flag.

The second element was to turn the U.S. bases in the region, built to project American power and protect its allies, into vulnerable targets. Tehran shut down the Strait of Hormuz through which roughly 20% of the world’s seaborne crude oil passed before the war. It turned the Persian Gulf into a battlefield and kept American warships out of it. The Iranian view was that if it was not allowed to export crude, nobody in the Gulf would be able to do so through the Strait. Surprisingly, the U.S. had no contingency plan for the closure of the Strait. Once the waterway was shut, the dynamics of the war began to shift. It was at that point that Mr. Trump began to lose the strategic initiative.

After 40 days of bombing, Mr. Trump announced a ceasefire on April 8. Since then, he has been searching for a dignified exit from the conflict. On June 17, he signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with Iran, under which Washington made significant concessions. Unable to present the MoU as a victory at home, however, Mr. Trump soon resumed military strikes, only to be met each time with Iranian retaliation. The ensuing cycle of escalation pushed Washington even farther from its original objectives, while Iran’s willingness to take risks continued to grow.

The war has inflicted immense damage to Iran’s military infrastructure and economy. Yet, Tehran, which has lived under U.S. sanctions for nearly five decades, seems willing to absorb the pain because it sees a strategic opportunity to reshape the regional balance of power at a time when the U.S. is confronting the limits of its own overreach.

America’s Iran war stalls as Tehran turns pressure into strategic advantage

Handloom — weaving India’s heritage into global growth

The making of a developed nation is not defined by technology alone. It is shaped by the ability to transform enduring strengths into engines of future growth. As India advances towards Viksit Bharat 2047, it is investing in frontier technologies, strengthening manufacturing and building globally competitive industries.

Yet, one of India’s greatest strengths has been with India all along – its handloom tradition. On August 7, as India marks the 12th National Handloom Day, it is time to view handloom as a strategic sector for a world that values sustainability, authenticity and resilient supply chains.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 is built on prosperity, self-reliance, inclusivity and cultural confidence. Handloom embodies this vision by bringing together heritage and innovation, while driving women-led development, rural entrepreneurship, livelihoods and global competitiveness.

Threads of India’s legacy

Every handwoven fabric reflects the courage to preserve tradition, the patience to perfect every thread, the integrity of honest craftsmanship and the wisdom passed down through generations. That is why handloom is not merely a craft, but one of India’s greatest civilisational strengths. From the Indus Valley Civilisation, where cotton was first cultivated and woven, to the 18th century when Indian textiles dominated global trade, India set global benchmarks in textile excellence. Bengal’s legendary muslin – so fine that a 25-metre length could pass through a ring – along with Banarasi silk, Kanchipuram weaves, Pochampally Ikat and countless regional traditions, earned India worldwide admiration.

Today, as the world turns towards authentic, sustainable and handcrafted products, India has a historic opportunity to reclaim that leadership.



Giriraj Singh

Union Minister of Textiles, Government of India

India’s ancient handloom traditions can transform heritage into a globally competitive creative economy

India’s next handloom revolution must export not just textiles, but also craftsmanship, heritage, innovation and trust, making every handwoven product an ambassador of Brand India.

Transformation through policy

Handloom is India’s largest cottage industry, supporting the livelihoods of more than 35 lakh weavers and allied workers, nearly 72% of whom are women. Over the past decade, the Government has strengthened the sector through the Raw Material Supply Scheme, 797 handloom clusters, over 1.24 lakh improved looms, skill upgradation for nearly 97,000 artisans, and initiatives such as Producer Companies, GI tagged products, the Handloom Mark, India Handmade certification, Urban Haats and Design Resource Centres.

Today, 29 Weavers’ Service Centres provide end to end support through training, upskilling, design development, raw material assistance and market linkages, while the 11 Indian Institutes of Handloom Technology are being strengthened to expand advanced training and develop niche, high-value handloom products. The forthcoming National Handloom and Handicraft Programme will accelerate this transformation by strengthening 1,800 clusters across more than 500 districts, benefiting 65 lakh weavers and artisans and establishing Handmade in India as a globally recognised brand.

Innovation has always been part of India’s handloom journey. Mahatma Gandhi’s Ambar Charkha made spinning easier, faster and more efficient, advancing the vision of self-reliance.

More recently, Assam’s Maina Loom and the Chitrnanjan Handloom developed in Sivasagar have shown how better loom design can make weaving easier and more productive. The Centre of Excellence for Handloom Technology, established with the Indian Institutes of Technology, is developing lighter, stronger and easier to use looms that reduce physical effort

As the war dragged on, Iran stepped out of the shadows of asymmetric warfare and increasingly shaped both the course and the pace of the conflict. When U.S. bombing resumed in July following the collapse of the MoU, Washington’s primary objective shifted to reopening the Strait of Hormuz, which had remained open until February 27. Four months into the war, Iran had forced the U.S. to set aside its original objectives – from regime change to the destruction of Iran’s nuclear programme – and instead contend with a new strategic problem created by Tehran itself. In July, while responding to U.S. strikes, Iran widened the conflict by intensifying attacks on Jordan and targeting Iraqi Kurdistan, Syria, and the Persian Gulf monarchies. Yemen’s Ansar Allah (the Houthis) struck Saudi oil facilities and imposed a naval blockade on the kingdom’s Red Sea ports. The conflict thus expanded horizontally in July, something which Mr. Trump was unprepared.

Trapped in escalation

Consider America’s major military campaigns in the 21st century. In Afghanistan, U.S. forces achieved an initial swift victory by toppling the Taliban and establishing a new political order. They began losing the war only after the Taliban began regrouping and started a sustained insurgency. In Iraq and Libya, Washington succeeded in bringing down the regimes, even though the interventions destroyed those states and societies. In each of those theatres, the U.S. at least achieved its immediate military objectives, before failing to manage the post-war order.

But in Iran, the U.S. lost the war in the first phase itself. The U.S. now faces a diminished presence in West Asia, while Iran, with Hormuz under its control, is reasserting itself as a Persian Gulf regional power. Mr. Trump is no longer talking about Iran’s missile programme, its foreign policy or the character of the Iranian state. Forget regime change; today, he is asking the Islamic Republic, the same regime he sought to topple, to make a deal with Washington.

Trapped in this Persian labyrinth, Mr. Trump has few good options. He can acknowledge defeat and exercise diplomatic patience to reach a deal with Tehran and extricate the U.S. from the conflict. For Washington, which has been the dominant power in the Persian Gulf at least since the 1956 Suez War, this would come at a significant strategic cost. Alternatively, Mr. Trump could turn his failed air campaign into a full-scale invasion, with more devastating strikes and the potential deployment of ground troops. But there is no guarantee that escalation would help him win the war. On the contrary, it could draw the U.S. deeper into the sands of Iran, where a military of roughly 6,00,000 soldiers would be waiting.

stanly.johny@thehindu.co.in

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

End the deadlock

Thanks to the relentless disruptions by the Opposition, Parliament has been unable to conduct any meaningful business since the start of the monsoon session (Front page, August 6). Parliament is the sanctum sanctorum in a democracy and should be a

forum for debate, not disruption. Nothing is lost if the government considers the Opposition’s two key demands. If doing so can help break the impasse, this must be pursued. The government must note that relying solely on its numerical strength will only deepen the stalemate. The

sooner this stand-off ends, the better it will be for parliamentary democracy. **V. Johan Dhanakumar**, Chennai

First Budget

The maiden Budget of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam government in Tamil Nadu deserves appreciation for

placing youth and women at the centre of its welfare agenda. Several of its initiatives will provide families with a modest financial cushion at milestones. The only jarring aspect is the naming of some of the schemes, which inadvertently reinforces

patriarchal notions that sit uneasily with the ideals of gender equality and women’s empowerment. The government’s decision to prioritise welfare despite fiscal constraints, banking on governance reforms to create additional fiscal space is significant. While the Budget’s intent is

laudable, the true test will be whether the government can sustain these generous welfare commitments without undermining fiscal discipline.

M. Jeyaram, Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The views expressed are personal

Should the Commonwealth Games be scrapped?



Anju Bobby George

is a distinguished sportsperson who is a recipient of the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna Award and is now the senior vice president of the Athletics Federation of India



Heena Sidhu

is a multiple-time champion at the CWG, winning a gold and a silver medal each at the 2010 and 2018 editions. In 2014, she became the first ever Indian pistol shooter to become world number one

PARLEY

The recently concluded Commonwealth Games (CWG) were unlike the usual multidisciplinary sporting extravaganzas that we are used to seeing. A late replacement to Victoria as host, the Glasgow Games were more akin to an abridged version with fewer events and fewer participants. India finished fourth on the medal table, a commendable performance given that most of the sports that have formed the bulk of our medal haul had been removed. But questions of uncertainty have been whirling around the Games for a long time. Should the Commonwealth Games be scrapped? Anju Bobby George and Dr. Heena Sidhu discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Uthra Ganesan**. Edited excerpts:

What is the importance of the CWG for sports in general and for India particularly?

Anju Bobby George: From an athlete's or athletics point of view, it is one of the biggest competitions after the Olympics and World Championships, coming before the Asian Games. Winning a medal in the Commonwealth Games is precious, and athletes take it very seriously. Initially, in 2002, we got only two medals; but in the recent CWG, our athletes bagged 10 medals.

When looking at the scale of the competition, in the World Championships and the Olympics, we compete with more than 210 countries. In the CWG, there are about 80 countries, and in the Asian Games, more than 40. As the number of countries goes up, the competition will also go up. So for us in athletics, the CWG comes in third place. Most of the elite, top-level, world-ranking athletes compete, making it very tough. Also, it is a preparation for the Olympics and World Championships.

Heena Sidhu: For shooting, World Championships are the toughest, followed by the Olympic Games, the Asian Games and then the CWG. The Asian Games is far tougher for shooters than the CWG, where competition is not even as tough as our National Championships. I would rank the CWG around a 4 out of 10 in difficulty, whereas World Championships are a 10 out of 10.

However, the games hold immense personal value and play a crucial role in preparation. Competing under pressure, living in the village, handling media, and representing India prepares you. Because the Asian Games is so tough, you cannot experiment there. The CWG is a place where shooters could experiment, understand their process, and take that



President of the Indian Olympic Association P.T. Usha hands the flag to Neeraj Chopra during the closing ceremony of CWG in Glasgow on August 2. REUTERS

momentum to the Asian Games and World Championships.

With shooting absent from recent editions, how does that impact the sport?

HS: It is a bittersweet feeling. Shooting will appear in the CWG after 12 years in 2030, with the last edition being 2018 where I won two medals. The CWG has always been very special to me because I have four medals and I know how important it was for me to go to these Games. Some of the defining moments of my career have come from there. The CWG removing shooting hurts because any broadcasting or media interest helps our sport, which is not often shown on television.

Shooting is being cut out from many events, including the Asian Games, as squad limits force federations to select athletes playing two or more events rather than bringing top rankers from every discipline. Additionally, issues such as European restrictions on lead pellets, and negative perceptions tied to mass shootings create hurdles. Shooting is considered spectator-unfriendly, as stands are empty in places such as Glasgow. However, Indian spectators want to see it. If we want to save the sport, countries with fan demand must host it.

How do you view challenges around hosting multi-sport events and squad restrictions?

ABG: Countries do not want to host multi-event sports due to costs, and they are reducing athlete numbers. This time, there was a restriction allowing only 32 athletes (16 men and 16 women) in athletics. Federations face a difficult situation because even qualified athletes cannot all be sent; we have to carefully select so that no medal winner is left behind. It is sad for athletes who qualify without knowing if they will



Modern multi-sport events such as the Olympics, the Asian Games and the CWG struggle because hosting at this scale is extremely expensive. Research shows that hosting the Olympics often leaves countries in severe debt and economic downfall, as seen in Greece and Brazil

HEENA SIDHU

go. But these are hurdles we have to tackle.

HS: Modern multi-sport events such as the Olympics, the Asian Games and the CWG struggle because hosting at this scale is extremely expensive. Research shows that hosting the Olympics often leaves countries in severe debt and economic downfall, as seen in Greece and Brazil, with China being an exception. I also know that the CWG as an institution is at a crossroads, and not everybody wants to host it. The traditional ways of hosting games are no longer valid in modern times. We definitely need to do something about it.

What can be the options that make sure that multi-disciplinary events like the Commonwealth Games actually survive?

ABG: Actually, that is what countries are doing now – like the FIFA World Cup, it was held in three different countries. On a smaller scale, we do it for the National Games, where we conduct different sports in different cities or districts. But personally for me, you miss the beauty of the Games that way. Those who are coming to watch the events will have to fly all over. When it's together, they can just watch shooting one day, go and watch athletics the next day, day after that go for wrestling and so on. That won't happen with multiple venues.

HS: It is obvious that it's very difficult to host events at this scale. Traditional hosting is no longer valid: countries and sports bodies need to collaborate, sit down and find a solution. If a host cannot accommodate certain sports, other countries could host specific events – such as India hosting shooting, badminton, or wrestling – rather than kicking those sports out entirely. This is something that the big sports bodies, including the International Olympic Committee, need to think about.

But I agree on the social aspect. If you go to the Olympics for one month, it's like a 'mini world', mingling with athletes from across the world and across sports. That is an experience that will definitely be missed.

What role does India play in the future of the CWG and hosting big events?

ABG: India is evolving and is ready to host big events. Financially, money is not an issue for us. Hosting the 2030 CWG is very important as a stepping stone towards our 2036 Olympic bid. By 2030, we can complete our infrastructure, so that by 2036 we would need only upgrades. Our athletes can train in those venues, and organisers can gain experience handling the pressures of big events. The entire sporting ecosystem will grow significantly, and if managed well, hosting will not backfire on India.

HS: India can definitely look at these Games as something that they can host regularly because once you make the infrastructure, you really don't have to invest much. And honestly, given the lack of a regular National Games programme in India – when was the last time we knew with surety that the National Games were going to happen – we need some kind of ecosystem where these kind of multidisciplinary games can happen. While initial investments in infrastructure, marketing, and fan engagement are high, getting it right can turbocharge our sporting business. Major global bodies like Wimbledon and FIFA are courting Indian fans because of the country's huge potential.

What are your final expectations for the 2030 Commonwealth Games and beyond?

ABG: For me, the 2030 CWG is a stepping stone towards the bigger dream of the 2036 Olympics. We must build momentum starting now, identifying 12 to 14-year-old talents in schools today and nurturing them for the Olympics in 10 years. India is currently in 4th place in the CWG medal tally; my dream is to see India finish in 1st place in 2030, and reach the top five at the Olympics in 2036.

HS: I am looking forward to 2030 because shooting returns after 12 years. India should use this opportunity to make shooting accessible and engaging for fans. If you think about the last CWG we hosted in 2010, it was a defining moment for Indian sports because after that, we had really good infrastructure that helped us launch our athletes for the 2012 and 2016 Olympics. By taking sports seriously and building proper engagement, India can build a strong sporting ecosystem for the future.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
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NOTEBOOK

The language of obscenity in Tamil Nadu politics

The arrest of the LoP for his allegedly crude remarks has rekindled memories of a time when leaders would scathingly attack their rivals

B. Kolappan

The arrest of the Leader of the Opposition in Tamil Nadu Udhayanidhi Stalin in connection with his allegedly obscene remarks during a demonstration on the Cauvery water dispute in Thanjavur has rekindled memories of an era when political leaders launched no-holds-barred attacks on their rivals.

In those days, political parties in Tamil Nadu had an unwritten division of labour. While senior leaders articulated the party's ideology and policies, fiery oratory speeches – often punctuated with personal attacks and, at times, obscene remarks – was largely left to second- and third-rung leaders of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), and, to a much lesser extent, the Congress.

These speakers had a devoted following. Their speeches were not merely exercises in invective; they forcefully explained the political issues of the day and defended their party's positions. Yet, every now and then, they would veer into caustic attacks on rival leaders, employing language that, despite its crudeness, was relished by sections of the audience.

I vividly remember a speech delivered by Theepori Arumugam, one of the DMK's most colourful platform speakers, in the aftermath of the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi. Renowned for his fiery style, he rarely exercised restraint and routinely launched obscene and deeply personal attacks on political rivals. On that occasion, he spared no one, even weaving in references about his own family life into his speech to entertain the crowd.

His inflammatory rhetoric also had consequences. On one occasion, angry members of a rival political party assaulted him, injuring the tip of his tongue. Ironically, after recovering from the injury, his speeches became even more scathing. Theepori Arumugam eventually joined the AIADMK – the very party he had spent years attacking with his acid tongue!

Party leaders generally turned a deaf

ear to such rhetoric. They intervened only when there was public backlash, suspending the speakers for a brief period. More often than not, the suspension proved temporary, and the speakers returned to the political stage with renewed vigour.

Though Mr. Udhayanidhi has courted controversy over his choice of words in the past, his remarks in Thanjavur appeared to have been made in response to repeated prodding from sections of the crowd. However, he went on to reiterate the expression. He subsequently denied that he had used words with a double entendre, insisting that his words had been misconstrued.

Women – both politicians and those associated with political leaders – have often been at the receiving end of public political invective in Tamil Nadu. Personal attacks directed at women have long formed an unfortunate strand of platform rhetoric, reflecting the deeply gendered nature of political discourse.

Though former Chief Minister J. Jayalalithaa herself was often the target of deeply personal attacks, it did not prevent her from making personal remarks against her opponents. During one election campaign, she targeted DMK Parliamentary Party leader Kanimozhi, and on more than one occasion had ridiculed senior DMK leaders, including M. K. Stalin. In a sense, Jayalalithaa also brought some of the combative style of platform politics into the Tamil Nadu Assembly. She displayed extraordinary aggression on the floor of the House, using forceful body language and a high-pitched, confrontational tone to take on her political adversaries. Her exchanges with the founder of the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), Vijayakanth, remain among the most dramatic confrontations in the Assembly's history.

That style of politics appears to have found echoes in the present Assembly. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's aggressive delivery during his exchanges with the DMK leadership have reminded many of Jayalalithaa's combative presence.

kolappan.b@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

At a steady pace



Miles to go: A Rabari shepherd from Rajasthan leads his herd of cattle in the Bhiwani district in Haryana on August 5. Rabaris are a nomadic and predominantly pastoralist group who travel across Gujarat and Rajasthan in search of green pastures. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 7, 1976

Second satellite model to be ready by next year

Bangalore, August 6: The engineering model of India's second satellite is now fast nearing completion at Peenya, a city suburb. A team of about 400 space scientists, engineers and others is busy keeping up the model schedule displaying a unique team spirit.

The space engineers at the Indian Scientific Satellite Project (ISSP) are in the age group of 25 to 32 and they appear to be as much excited



and interested in the design, fabrication and testing of the second satellite as they were about the first satellite "Aryabhata".

Dr. U.R. Rao, Director of the ISSP, told a Samachar correspondent who visited the project to-day that he found among his staff the same enthusiasm and team spirit that enabled the successful fabrication and testing of the "Aryabhata" for making the second satellite now. The second satellite, called the Satellite for Earth Observation (SEO), will conduct experimental studies in the earth observation with special application in areas of meteorology, oceanography and forestry. It is expected to be launched from a USSR cosmodrome in 1977-78.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 7, 1926

British industrial mission to America

Rugby, August 6: It is understood that a Commission which with the approval of British Government will proceed to the United States to enquire into industrial conditions there will consist of five members. Two will be representative of the Trade Union movement, two will represent the employers and the Commission will be headed by Sir William Mackenzie, who has served on many important industrial enquiries.

An official of the Ministry of Labour will accompany the Commission.

From Page One

DMK lays down terms to back delimitation Bill

Though the government doesn't have the two-thirds majority yet to push through a constitutional amendment, the political situation has changed since April 17, when the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill was defeated on the floor of the House. The numerical strength of the INDIA bloc has since vastly changed.

In the present 540-member Lok Sabha, the two-thirds majority mark is 360, and if 22 Lok Sabha members of the DMK vote for the Bill, the government's strength would go up to 346. While the government would still be short of 14 MPs, the threshold changes if there are abstentions during the proceedings. If the government brings the Bill to the Rajya Sabha, it will find it easier to reach the two-thirds majority mark. In the Rajya Sabha, if all 244 members are present for voting, the government will need 164 votes. The BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) currently has 158 MPs.

Home Minister Amit Shah had earlier said that once it is assured of the numbers, the government would once again bring the constitutional amendment Bill to increase the strength of the Lok Sabha to 850 seats in order to implement the 33% reservation for women after fresh delimitation.

Since April, the government has secured the support of 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs, who are now part of the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPD), and six Shiv Sena MPs who had switched sides from the Uddhav Thackeray faction to the Eknath Shinde-led faction.

HC convicts Tejpal in 2013 sexual assault case

According to the prosecution, Tejpal sexually assaulted a junior colleague inside a hotel elevator in 2013 during an event organised by the magazine in Goa. In its 81-page judgment, the court expressed disapproval about the way the defence highlighted the complainant's personal life, and noted that it found it surprising that the trial court "remained silent and allowed the defence to harass and humiliate her during the cross examination".

The court said that the prosecution had established its case "beyond every reasonable doubt" and the victim too had stood firm in her testimony. The trial court had proceeded with the notion that a sexual assault complainant must behave in a stereotypical manner, the court said.

"The 'perfect victim' concept, more formally known as an 'ideal victim', described an unspoken cultural archetype where a person is fully believed, sympathised with and granted legitimacy only if they exhibit absolute vulnerability, complete innocence and total passivity," the court said. When a victim does not fit the description, the trauma is devalued, it added.

While Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta requested the court to award the maximum sentence, senior advocate Abad Ponda, representing Tejpal, appealed for leniency, stating that this was Tejpal's first offence and he was 62 years old.

"Let me be given an opportunity to approach the Supreme Court," Mr. Ponda said on behalf of Tejpal. He assured the court that Tejpal was not going to flee from the law. Tejpal, with permission from the court, addressed the Bench. "For the last 13 years, we have been working to bring facts and truth to light. Obviously, that holds no significance today. I am a father to two daughters, and I have a family. All I want to say is that we now have the option to appeal in a higher court," he said.

The court convicted Tejpal under Sections 376 (2)(f), 376(2)(k), 354A, and 354B of the Indian Penal Code and also imposed a fine of ₹5 lakh under Section 376(2)(f).

(With inputs from PTI)

Jharkhand protesters form 11-member team to meet govt.

Students say the agitation will continue until the govt. takes a concrete decision on their demands; key demand is a CBI inquiry; Jharkhand CID has arrested 19 people in connection with the case

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Students protesting in Jharkhand on Thursday formed an 11-member delegation to hold talks with the Jharkhand government over their demands.

Hundreds of students gathered at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in State capital Ranchi, demanding an inquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) followed by action against those responsible for the alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs in the State, including in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) Combined Civil Services Examination, and the Jharkhand General Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination, which is also known as Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) exam.

The JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch was scheduled to hold talks with the four-member committee formed by the government on Thursday evening. However, till filing this report, no message had been sent to the Manch with regard to the timing and place of the talks. However, the Manch has sent the names of the 11 delegates who will be part of the talks.

Demands to be tabled

The delegation included eight students – Ravindra Paswan, Piyush Kumar Singh, Ravindra Kumar Ravi, Rajesh Prasad, Neetu Kujur, Kartik Soren, Sandeep Kumar and Shaalu Singh. Along with them, there will be one journalist representing the media,



Student leader Devendra Nath Mahto during a hunger strike as part of the protest against alleged irregularities in the JPSC exam, JSSC-CGL and other recruitment tests in Ranchi on Thursday. PTI

one person in the role of guardian and one legal expert.

The JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch has asserted that journalists and legal experts will be present in the capacity of mentors to the students, and have been instructed not to engage in any conversation and not to carry microphones, cameras or any recording devices to the meeting.

During the dialogue, all issues, facts, and demands will be presented to the government only by the student representatives in a peaceful and orderly manner. Student representative Ravindra Paswan said students were ready for talks with the government. "Our objective is to put the real demands of the students before the government. We hope that the government will listen to us seriously and take positive decisions in the interest of the students," he said.

19 arrested so far

Meanwhile, the peaceful protest entered its 13th day on Thursday. The students have asserted that their agitation would continue until the government takes a concrete decision on their demands.

The Jharkhand Crime Investigation Department (CID) is investigating the irregularities and has arrested 19 persons in the case.

The main demand of the protesting students is a CBI inquiry into the issue. The protesters have also called for the cancellation of the Preliminary Test of the 14th JPSC Civil Services Examination, and a review of exams conducted through agencies, including TSR Data Processing Private Limited.

All govts. must listen, says Cong. as it backs Jharkhand students

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Rahul Gandhi

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Thursday took questions from students, including one on the protests by students in Jharkhand against paper leak, and asserted that every government should listen to them.

Launching an "Ask Me Anything" session on Instagram, Mr. Gandhi said the protests reflected deep dissatisfaction with an education system that had become "expensive and oppressive".

"Every government should listen to the students and take action to change the education system. Whether it is the Congress government, the Central government or the Jharkhand government," he said.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said the party would support students irrespective of whether the government concerned was led by an ally or a political rival. "We will ask whether we have made a mistake, and why it has happened," he said, adding that the party would write to the Jharkhand government.

Earlier, AICC in-charge for Jharkhand K. Raju said he had met Chief Minister Hemant Soren and submitted a memorandum on the students' demands, while welcoming the government's decision to constitute a ministerial committee to engage with the protesters.

The Congress also accused the Uttar Pradesh government of attempting to prevent Mr. Gandhi's proposed *Chhatron Ki Goonj* (Voice of Students' programme in Prayagraj, scheduled for August 8. U.P. Congress in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam alleged that the administration was pressuring those associated with the venue to cancel permissions despite the party complying with all legal requirements.

Gen Z's grievances must be addressed: RSS chief

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI



Mohan Bhagwat

Gen Z's grievances are genuine and need to be addressed, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Monday. Speaking days after the massive youth protest at Jantar Mantar, the RSS chief said that protest is a way of dialogue in a democracy, and that it should be used to evolve a consensus.

He was participating in an interview at an event organised by India's International Movement to Unite Nations, a youth-run non-profit, at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre.

Disagreeing with the tag of "anti-nationals" slapped on the young protesters by some people, Mr. Bhagwat said that Gen Z was in fact much more honest than his generation.

cies, climate change, and unemployment – were collected from members of Gen Z and Gen Alpha. The interview was moderated by IIMUN's Rishabh Shah, who was cheered by the crowd when he asked questions about youth being labelled as anti-national, empowerment of women within the RSS, and the Sangh's stance on same sex marriages.

On same sex couples

Mr. Bhagwat called for a law to allow same sex companions to stay together, though not in the form of a marriage. "LGBTQIs are a part of our community. But in our community, marriage is not a convenience created for two persons to stay together. It is an institution. Family is the unit of society where the next generation is trained by their relations," he said.

After Jantar Mantar, CJP eyes national footprint

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI



Abhijeet Dipke

Less than two weeks after ending its successful agitation at Jantar Mantar, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) is ready to move to the next level. The group announced a nationwide membership drive, a public dialogue initiative, and an expansion plan, apart from naming its first national working committee. The announcements were made on Thursday, at the end of a two-day core committee meeting at Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar in Maharashtra.

Announcing the launch of its "*Kya Bolti Public*" initiative (which translates to "What do you say, public?"), the CJP said it was keen to listen to the voices of ordinary people from different parts of the country. It also plans to launch a

crowd-funding initiative to support its expansion. It will continue to focus on education reforms, but will also highlight electoral and judicial reforms and seek to enforce institutional and media accountability.

Founder and national convener Abhijeet Dipke said that the group would go to the grassroots level and build a culture among the people of seeking accountability from political systems. "We want to change the political discourse. Youth issues will have to be taken up, whoever fights the elections. We will not support or oppose a political party," he said.

He took a swipe at RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat over the timing of his interaction with members of Gen Z, arguing that it was the Jantar Mantar protest that had forced the RSS to stop dismissing the concerns of the youth. The CJP's first national working committee puts young millennials and older members of Gen Z at the helm of the organisation, with the leadership ranging in age from 25 years to 35 years. A zonal architecture is being put in place to create organisational structures across the country. The CJP's organisational structure is to be divided into five zones across the country.

SC stays arrest of Abhishek Banerjee's personal aide

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed the arrest of Sumit Roy, personal assistant to Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee, in connection with the Salboni land-grabbing case.

The Bench however, directed him to cooperate fully with the ongoing investigation. On August 3, 2026 the Calcutta High Court rejected the anticipatory bail plea of Mr. Roy.

The case was registered under penal provisions relating to cheating, criminal breach of trust, use of forged documents, and criminal conspiracy.

"The petitioner shall remain available for investigation from 10:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. However, his arrest will remain stayed," the Bench ordered.

SC to consider Cong. MP's plea alleging Form-7 misuse in U.P.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has agreed to consider a plea by Congress MP Tanuj Punia highlighting widespread misuse and fraud in connection with Form-7 during the claims-and-objections phase of the Uttar Pradesh Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process.

Form-7 is a statutory mechanism under the Registration of Electors Rules of 1960, intended to enable limited and *bona fide* objections to the inclusion of names in the electoral roll, or deletion on narrowly defined grounds.

Appearing before a Bench headed by the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday, senior advocates Salman Khushud and advocate Shariq Ahmed, representing Mr. Punia, said there was documented evidence to show that the Form-7 process had been utilised to facilitate bulk, fraudulent and targeted deletion attempts against eligible electors, "particularly of those belonging to minority and marginalised sections of society".

The MP has arraigned the Election Commission of India and the Chief Electoral Officer of Uttar Pradesh as respondents.

The application referred to instances of Booth Level Officers having received pre-filled Form 7 applications seeking deletion of multiple electors, including electors who had already been verified during the SIR process. "The objections are repetitive, bulk in nature, and mechanically invoke identical grounds without any accompanying particulars or credible basis," the application said.

Modi and Netanyahu discuss West Asia issues

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday received a telephone call from his Israeli counterpart Benjamin Netanyahu during which they exchanged views on the recent developments in West Asia.

The two leaders also reviewed sustained progress in the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership and reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening the bilateral cooperation across various sectors to benefit both countries, a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) said.

In a post on X, Mr. Modi said, "We reviewed progress on various aspects of the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership which continues to grow from strength-to-strength."

Question paper leaks are more heinous than murder, says HC

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

The Chhattisgarh High Court has observed that leaking question papers for competitive examinations and jeopardising the future of lakhs of students is an offence more heinous than murder. The remark came while dismissing the bail plea of Janak Kumar Dhruv, an accused in the alleged Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGPSC) recruitment scam.

The case pertains to the alleged corruption, question-paper leak and manipulation of the CGPSC State Service Examinations conducted in the years 2021 and 2022.

"...A person who facilitates leakage of question papers for competitive examinations plays with the careers and futures of

lakhs of young aspirants... Such an act is more heinous than murder because, while the killing of a person affects one family, the destruction of the careers of lakhs of aspirants adversely impacts society as a whole," noted the judgment delivered by the single-judge Bench of Bibhu Datta Guru.

Mr. Dhruv, who served as the Secretary of the CGPSC during the relevant period, is accused of helping his son, Sumit Dhruv, secure selection as a Deputy Collector.

Counsel for the applicant, however, argued that Mr. Dhruv had been falsely implicated in the case.

The court rejected the bail application and said that the alleged charges levelled against the accused persons could by no stretch of imagination be termed ordinary.

Celebrate National Handloom Day: PM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday urged Indians to mark National Handloom Day, which falls on Friday, by sharing videos of their favourite handloom products.

Posting on his Instagram account, Mr. Modi was seen handling various pieces of handloom material from different parts of the country. He recalled that the Swadeshi movement of

boycotting foreign goods in favour of Indian goods was launched on August 7, 1905.

He urged people to remember handloom workers and their contribution. "Let's make India's handloom diversity popular. Share your videos with your favourite handloom products, including GRWM videos. Don't forget to use #NationalHandloomDay," he said. GRWM (Get Ready With Me) is a popular Internet trend.



Mr. Harsh Makhijani, Christian Medical College Hospital No. AE07421, 18 years has been diagnosed to have Thalassemia major. This is a type of Blood Disorder which is life threatening. The treatment option for him would be to undergo Allogeneic stem cell Transplantation (PBSCT). The estimated cost of MUD transplant at our centre will come to Approximately Rs.55,00,000/-.

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D/M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives** A/c Harsh Makhijani. **Our A/c Details:** S/B A/c No. 20000913487. S.B.I. R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE: SBIN001855. Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377. UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksb. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.

SAVE POOR LIVES, Flat No. A1, Ceebros Garden, Door No.14/76, Kamarajar Salai, Raja Annamalaiapuram, Chennai-600028. Ph. No. 044 42044165 / 9884607377. Email: savepoorlives@gmail.com. Our website: www.savepoorlives.com

APPEAL



FCRA Bill is ‘religion-neutral’, Shah assures Christian bodies

Bill likely to be taken up for discussion in Parliament on August 12; Home Minister tells Christian delegations that the govt. has ‘no intention to harass the Christian community’; forum requests Bill be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Amid concerns raised by Christian bodies over the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 (FCRA), Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday met two delegations, including one representing all Christian denominations and communities, and assured them that the proposed legislation was “religion-neutral”.

A member of the delegation said Mr. Shah asserted that the “government has no intention to harass the Christian community, or any faith (or) community for that matter”.

The other delegation included Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma, who said that Mr. Shah had conveyed that the Bill was likely to be taken up for discussion in Parliament on August 12, a day before the Monsoon Session ends. “We were given an assurance that the provisions of the Bill will not be applied retrospectively,” he said.

Reverend Asir Ebenezer,



Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma with Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi, in this file photo. ANI

er, general secretary of National Council of Churches in India, who met Mr. Shah, said the 18-member delegation of the Joint Action Forum on Minorities included representatives from all the three Christian traditions – Catholic, Protestant, and Orthodox.

“We had written to the Prime Minister to register our concerns against the FCRA Bill. The Home Minister gave us time and listened to us patiently for an hour. He said it is not against the Christian faith but against anyone who violates the law. We re-

quested him that a comprehensive review of the Act that was introduced in 2010 is required,” Mr. Ebenezer told *The Hindu*.

Main concern

One of the key provisions in the FCRA Bill, 2026, is the appointment of a “designated authority” to take over, manage, or dispose of assets created from foreign funds when an NGO’s FCRA registration is suspended, cancelled, or not renewed. This authority will have the powers of a civil court and can order the transfer or sale of assets

owned by NGOs to either the government or any other body. The Bill was initially listed for passage in the ongoing Monsoon Session of the Parliament but did not figure in this week’s list of business.

Mr. Ebenezer said that the “deemed cessation” of assets in case the FCRA registration is not renewed or cancelled by the government in absence of a formal order was also flagged at the meeting.

“The Minister asked us for a list of cases where registrations of NGOs had been cancelled without any notice. We also sought clarity on the powers of the vesting authority to dispose the assets without a judicial oversight. How can a government authority just take over my property?” he asked.

The meeting is among a series of interactions that the Home Minister has held with the Christian community to assuage concerns over the Bill.

On July 10, Mr. Shah assured the Catholic Bishops Conference of India, the apex body of the Catholic church in India, that the

Bill was not against the Christian NGOs, which receive a little under 15% of the total foreign donations.

DMK MP P. Wilson, chairman of the Joint Forum, who led the delegation, said, “We clearly spelt out the illegalities in the Bill. Even if a registration is going to be cancelled, there was no necessity to take over the properties of these organisations... it was also explained to the Home Minister that these bodies have employed expert hands for running these organisations, institutions, hospitals, and by taking over it will clearly destroy them, including the hospitals...”

The delegation submitted a representation requesting the withdrawal of the Bill in its present form. It requested that the Bill be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee for comprehensive stakeholder consultation.

Government sources ruled out further changes to the Bill adding that the specifics on taking over assets by designated authority will be clarified when the Rules are notified.

RS Chairman tells Rijiju to ‘echo the sentiments’ of the Opposition to Shah

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

On the 14th day of the Monsoon Session, Rajya Sabha Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan on Thursday asked Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju to “echo the sentiments of the Opposition” to Home Minister Amit Shah. The session has been marked by disruptions, especially in the first half of the day.

The Rajya Sabha saw two adjournments in the morning session. Twenty minutes into the sitting, with Opposition sloganeering drowning out the Zero Hour speeches of members, Mr. Rijiju raised a point of order. Citing two rules that bar interruptions during speeches by members and allow the Chair to truncate speeches in cases where members are repeating their arguments, he said, “Mr. Kharage has been saying the same thing every day. There is a rule against repetition.”

He said the newly elected Congress MP Pawan Khara had not even delivered his maiden speech in the House but was sloganeering. The House was adjourned at 11.25 a.m.



Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan conducts the proceedings of the House during the Monsoon Session of Parliament on Thursday. ANI

When it reconvened at noon for Question Hour, the protests continued.

Heeding the Opposition’s request, Mr. Radhakrishnan asked the Leader of the Opposition, Mallikarjun Kharge, to speak. The Treasury Benches objected to this. Amid the noisy exchange, Mr. Kharge said, “If I don’t read the rules, if I don’t read my matter, should I read what you (Mr. Rijiju) give? It’s my right, what to speak, when to speak, how to speak.”

Mr. Kharge said the Opposition raised genuine questions concerning the country and its 140 crore people. “We are asking the Home Minister and the Prime Minister to come to the House. We request the

Chair to direct the Home Minister to come and give a statement. We are ready to discuss it,” he said.

Mr. Radhakrishnan said the Opposition had been asking the Home Minister to come to the House. “Now I request you to consider his (Kharge’s) request... As Parliamentary Affairs Minister, you can echo the sentiments of the Opposition to the HM,” Mr. Radhakrishnan said.

Addressing a press conference later, Mr. Kharge expressed satisfaction with the Chairman’s direction. He claimed that there could be only two reasons to explain the Home Minister’s absence. Either he believes that “Parliament does not matter” or he is “scared”, he said.

Centre spent over ₹550 cr. on PM Modi’s foreign visits

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The government spent around ₹557.51 crore between 2021 and July 2026 on Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s foreign visits, the External Affairs Ministry stated in the Rajya Sabha on Thursday.

Responding to a question from V. Sivadasan of the CPI(M), Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita said Mr. Modi visited 77 countries during this period.

The 35-page response among other details mentioned that this year for the February 25-26 Israel visit by Mr. Modi, the government spent around ₹11.92 crores. For Mr. Modi’s joint France and U.S. visit of February 10-13, 2025, the government spent ₹25.59 crore and ₹16.54 crore, respectively.

The government also informed Parliament that 316 Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were signed with various countries during this period. It mentioned that overall FDI inflow during this time was ₹381.8 billion.

House panel flags fertilizer shortage, calls for proper mechanism to address it

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Citing recurring reports of shortages, farmer protests, and distribution-related disruptions despite repeated assurances about adequate availability of fertilizers, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Chemicals and Fertilizers demanded the Union government institutionalise a permanent joint fertilizer command and monitoring cell, comprising the Department of Fertilizers, the Department of Agriculture, the Railways, and the State governments to provide “continuous, real-time coordination” on the supply of fertilizers during every cropping season.

The report on the “Alignment of logistics for efficient fertilizer movement and availability at affordable prices during peak season and steps taken to curb forced bundling of unnecessary boosters with essential fertilizers”, which was tabled on Thursday in both Houses, also said the Un-



Kirti Azad

ion government’s interventions to ensure adequate supply of input materials for fertilizer production during the ongoing war in West Asia were “largely reactive” and not guided by “a pre-existing institutionalised contingency framework” for foreseeable disruptions at critical maritime chokepoints, including the Strait of Hormuz.

Last-mile distribution

The panel, headed by Trinamool Congress MP Kirti Azad, also noted that the Centre limits its role to ensuring State-level availability, with the last-mile distribution treated “solely as” a State responsibility, blam-

ing such an approach as inadequate for addressing recurring supply bottlenecks.

Noticing “persistent underperformance” of new generation urea plants, the panel said they continued to operate significantly below their potential despite being counted amongst the country’s latest manufacturing facilities.

It recommended that all future technology transfer, and engineering and equipment supply contracts for fertilizer public sector undertakings and joint ventures must incorporate robust performance guarantees and warranty obligations to ensure the financial consequences of technology failure were borne by the supplier and not by the public exchequer.

It also recommended an urgent plant-wise diagnostic assessment of underutilised and idle diammonium phosphate units to identify the raw material, technical, commercial and operational constraints limiting production.

P.J. Kurien urges Speaker to ensure Home Minister’s presence in LS

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Former Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman and veteran Congress leader P.J. Kurien on Thursday urged Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla to “perform the duty of directing” Union Home Minister Amit Shah to be present in the House and respond to the questions raised by the Opposition members.

In a letter to the Speaker, Mr. Kurien said that as a citizen of the country, he was disappointed over the “non-functioning” of the House and its “failure” to ensure the accountability of the government and avoid the “consequent stalemate”. Noting that the Lok Sabha was not functioning for about one week because the Union Home Minister was “not coming to the House to respond to the questions of his department raised by the Opposition members”, he said in a democracy, the Opposition had an equally important role to play as the ruling party.

Constitutional duty

He said the government was accountable to Parliament and it was the constitutional duty of the Opposition to ensure accountability. It was the constitutional duty of the Speaker to protect the rights of members in their effort to ensure accountability, said Mr. Kurien, adding that if the Union Home Minister “evaded” Parliament continuously, he was “failing to perform his constitutional duty”.

Congress is not allowing Parliament to function: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The BJP on Thursday accused the Congress of spreading “false narratives” and preventing Parliament from functioning, while attacking Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi over the alleged examination irregularities in Jharkhand.

At a press briefing, BJP MP and former Union Minister Ravi Shankar Prasad said that Mr. Gandhi and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge were causing repeated

disruptions in Parliament. He said Mr. Gandhi and Mr. Kharge “come up with new stories every day and arrive with new posters”.

Mr. Prasad said the Jharkhand government had entrusted several examinations to a blacklisted company. “The same company that was blacklisted by the governments of Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan has been assigned responsibility for conducting several examinations in Jharkhand,” he said. “Rahul Gandhi is a hypocrite. He says one thing here while remaining silent there,” he added.

RS clears Appropriation Bill for expenditure of ₹54,067 crore

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amid protests and a walkout by Opposition members demanding the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah in the House, the Rajya Sabha on Thursday considered and returned the Appropriation Bill, 2026 that allows the expenditure of around ₹54,067 crore incurred during the 2022-23 financial year.

Replying to a brief discussion on the Bill, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the excess expenditure arose under

two heads and had already been examined by the Public Accounts Committee (PAC). She noted that the demands formed part of the PAC’s 39th Report, which was presented to the Lok Sabha in April.

Ms. Sitharaman said an excess demand of ₹196.44 crore stemmed from a court order relating to the Ministry of Railways, while the larger demand of ₹53,871 crore was towards debt repayment.

Responding to a demand for greater financial assistance to Jammu and Kashmir, the Finance Minister said the Centre bears

the entire salary and pension of Jammu and Kashmir Police, amounting to approximately ₹13,000 crore annually.

“We paid back the entire debt of Ladakh and after taking care of readjustments, restructured J&K’s debt. Also, for the years 2024-25 and 2025-26, an additional amount of ₹5,000 crore each year has been given, over and above the revised estimates of their budgets, to make sure the urgent requirements of the J&K administration [are met] and it is not left without anybody’s support,” Ms. Sitharaman said.

अजमेर विकास प्राधिकरण, अजमेर
अजमेर शहर, विकास कार्य, अजमेर, Email :- ajmeradev@gmail.com,
Website :- www.rajasthan.gov.in/ada, Tel.No. :- 0145-2627748-2627749
प्रजापति - अजमेर (रा.2/राजनीति)/2026-27/राजकाय 23723839 दिनांक - 31/07/2026

E-TENDER - 21/2026-27
Bids for Design, supply, installation, testing and commissioning of integrated Audio-visual, Projection mapping, Laser, lighting system and multimedia content generation for light and sound show at pushkar amounting Rs. 1197-19 Lacs are invited from interested bidders for up to 19.08.2026, 6:00 PM. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>) & (<http://sppp.raaj.nic.in>) <http://www.urban.rajasthan.gov.in/ada> departmental website. UBN No. : A/JD2627WLOB00125
Raj.Samwad/C/26/8808 Executive Engineer

**OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
UPPER INDRAVATI RIGHT CANAL DIVISION NO.II
AT/PO. JUNAGARH, DIST. : KALAHANDI**
Auction Sale Notice

The undersigned has invited 5 Nos of Auction Sale Notice for selling T & P materials "as is where basis" in the premises of Superintending Engineer, Right canal Division No-II, Junagarh on date - **12.08.2026 at 11.00 A.M.**

Name of the work	Auction Sale
Auction Schedule	Date-12.08.2026 at 11.00 AM Place- Office of the Superintending Engineer, U.I.R.C.D.No-II, Junagarh
Annexures	1. Auction Sale details and Conditions 2. Item Description for Auction Sale (Annexure-1)
Special Instruction	Details of the Items and Conditions of Auction Sale are displayed on the Notice board of Divisional Officer.

**Superintending Engineer,
Right Canal Division No.II, Junagarh.**

32001/651/2627 OIPR-32001/32016/126-27/0001

NAVODAYA VIDYALAYA SAMITI
Engagement of Project Staff for Vigyan Jyoti Phase-VII (2026-27)

S. No.	Name of Position	Essential Qualification	Upper Age Limit	Remuneration
1.	Project Scientist-I (1 Post)	Doctoral Degree in Science or Master's Degree in Engineering or Technology from a recognized University or equivalent	40 Years	Rs. 56,000/- + HRA
2.	Accountant (1 Post)	B.Com from any recognized university. Desirable: Three years' experience of Account work in Government / Semi-Government Autonomous Organization.	35 Years	Rs. 40,000/- (Consolidated)

The project staff will be engaged for a period of one year on contract or coterminous with the project, whichever is earlier, they will work with the Project Office **Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti, Noida** or any other assigned location. Preference will be given to candidates with experience in science outreach programs and project management.

The qualifications details and application form are available on NVS official website <https://navodaya.gov.in>. Interested applicants are invited to submit their applications in the format given at **Annexure-I** to the **Project Coordinator, Vigyan Jyoti, NVS, Noida** via email at vigyanjyotivns@gmail.com by **10th Aug, 2026**.

**Vigyan Jyoti Section
Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti**

ANNEXURE-I

Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti: Vigyan Jyoti Project
Application for the Post of Project Scientist-I/ Accountant

1. Application for the Post :
2. Name of the Applicant :
3. Father /Husband Name :
4. Category (General / SC / ST / OBC) :
5. Date of Birth :
6. Age as on 01.08.2026
7. Aadhaar No. :
8. Address for Correspondence :
9. Contact No. (Mob) :
10. Email ID :
11. Educational Qualification (in Chronological order from Senior Secondary (Class-XII on wards) (Copies of supporting documents are to be enclosed):

Affix your latest passport size photograph

S. No.	Examination Passed	Year of Passing	Board/ University	Subject Taken	% of marks obtained (up to 2 decimal points)

12. Experience (in chronological order) (Documentary evidence is to be closed)

S. No.	Post held	Organization	Period From To	Nature of Duties	Remarks

DECLARATION
I solemnly declare the statements and details given above in the application form are correct to the best of my knowledge and belief. In case of any of the details in the application form are found false at a later state, my candidature/engagement may be cancelled/withdrawn.
Date:

(Signature of the Candidate)

INBRIEF



Agni-4 medium-range ballistic missile test-fired from Odisha

The medium-range ballistic missile Agni-4 was successfully test-fired from the Integrated Test Range at Chandipur, Odisha, on Thursday, with the launch validating all operational and technical parameters. The test was carried out under the aegis of Strategic Forces Command, the Defence Ministry said. The successful launch demonstrated the missile's operational readiness and confirmed that all critical systems performed in line with expected parameters, the Ministry said. Agni-4 is an indigenously developed medium-range ballistic missile capable of delivering conventional and nuclear payloads.

SC refuses bail to Asaram, allows caretaker of his choice

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to grant interim bail on medical grounds to self-styled godman Asaram, but permitted him to engage a caretaker of his choice for round-the-clock medical assistance in jail. On May 27, Rajasthan High Court upheld the life sentence imposed on the octogenarian for sexually assaulting a minor devotee at his Jodhpur ashram in 2013. A Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and P.B. Varale took on record a medical report on Asaram's health condition. The report concluded while he did not require hospitalisation, he may need medical assistance. The top court also gave him liberty to seek interim relief if his condition deteriorated.

Govt. opposes income-based creamy layer in SC/ST quotas

Judicial precedent has clarified that the concept is not applicable to scheduled groups, it tells SC; most schemes have a means test ensuring 'benefits percolate to those who deserve them', it adds

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

Opposing a batch of petitions in the Supreme Court seeking the exclusion of the "creamy layer" from the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and the Scheduled Tribes (STs), on the lines of the system in place for the Other Backward Classes (OBC), the Union government has argued that judicial precedents had clarified that the "principles of creamy layer are not applicable to SCs and STs".

The Social Justice and Empowerment Ministry further told the top court in an affidavit that in a "majority" of welfare and development schemes for the SCs, STs, and OBCs, except reservation in educational institutes and services under the State, there was already a "means test which ensures that benefits of schemes percolate to those who actually deserve them".

The stand comes after the apex court in February issued a notice on the petitions. The court had also asked the Centre to file an Action Taken Report after



the 2024 Supreme Court decision that paved the way for sub-categorisation among the SCs and STs.

No such report appears to have been filed with this affidavit.

'Need holistic review'

In its submission, the Ministry said, "Modification of reservation policy, particularly to introduce income-based preferences within reserved categories, should be preceded by a holistic review and thorough empirical study, including socio-economic data of reserved category beneficiaries."

It said the main objective of the reservation policy for the SC, ST and OBC groups was to "achieve so-

cial equality and justice, overcome historical disadvantages and discrimination, ensure economic empowerment and upliftment for marginalised communities, and promote their inclusive participation in education, public services, and decision-making processes".

Further, the government has said that the current matter neither raises a constitutional issue nor discloses the violation of any fundamental right under the Constitution.

It went on to say that the petitioners had "indulged in misstatement of facts solely with the intention of misleading" the court.

The Ministry was referring to certain parts of the

Panel grills Defence Ministry on payment delay, hospital lapses

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



K.C. Venugopal

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) of Parliament, headed by senior Congress leader K.C. Venugopal, questioned the Defence Ministry on the report of the Comptroller and Auditor-General (CAG) that pointed to persistent delays in payment disbursement for junior commissioned officers. The CAG examined the functioning of Principal Controller of Defence Accounts (Officers) and 46 Pay and Accounts Offices, which managed payments and allowances worth ₹3,09,975.07 crore between 2020-21 and 2022-23.

The audit found that on an average it took 68 to 80 days to process payments. Over six lakh orders were rejected manually without recorded reasons, and 50,646 personnel were denied the Risk and Hardship Allowance because the rejected orders went untracked. The retirement settlement process also came under scrutiny.

On military hospitals, the audit covered 19 facilities and two medical store depots between 2017-18 and 2021-22. Parts of a military hospital in Lans-

downe collapsed in June 2022 after audits were skipped. The panel pressed the Ministry on accountability for the collapse, and asked whether officers who ignored 2014 structural audit instructions had been identified.

Members also raised operation of X-ray machines at six hospitals without radiation safety licences and asked for confirmation that all equipment hold certification. On medicine supply, audited depots met only 27% to 43% of hospital demand, pushing facilities toward costlier local purchases. They also sought a solution for hospitals unable to install effluent treatment plants.

The Ministry said several corrective measures were under way, including a new IT integration module and a draft Cabinet panel on Security note for hospital modernisation.

BCI asks varsities to inspect law colleges, bars weekend classes

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

The Bar Council of India (BCI) has directed all universities to physically inspect all affiliated and constituent law colleges under their jurisdiction and submit a consolidated compliance report within six weeks. It has also ordered an end to weekend, evening, and shift-based law programmes used to overcome shortages of classrooms, faculty, and other infrastructure.

In a circular issued on Tuesday, the BCI asked Vice-Chancellors, Registrars and heads of law faculties to conduct comprehensive inspections before granting or continuing affiliation. "The object is not to disrupt genuine institutions or prejudice students, but to ensure that every law degree recognised for enrolment as an advocate is earned through real teaching, qualified



The BCI directs universities to submit a report in six weeks.

full-time faculty, adequate infrastructure and meaningful practical training," the BCI said.

The directions follow a July 29 judgment of the Andhra Pradesh High Court in *All Saints Christian Education Society vs State of Andhra Pradesh* case. The court held that universities have a continuing duty to ensure that law colleges comply with the minimum standards prescribed under the Rules of Legal Education. It also observed that universities could face statutory consequences for granting affilia-

tion to institutions that fail to meet those standards.

The BCI said law colleges cannot run courses through morning, evening, weekend, compressed or shift-based schedules to compensate for inadequate infrastructure. Such arrangements, it said, dilute the regular character of legal education and must stop immediately.

'Verify records'

Inspection teams have been asked to verify land records, classrooms, libraries, moot court halls, legal aid clinics, sports facilities and statutory clearances. They must also examine faculty appointments, teacher-student ratios, and attendance records. It warned that failure to carry out proper inspections or allowing admissions without valid approvals would invite action under the Advocates Act and the Rules of Legal Education.

Starvation pushing mother to kill child a 'collective failure': HC

Abhinav Deshpande
AHMEDABAD

The Gujarat High Court has granted regular bail to a Surat woman accused of beating her two-year-old daughter to death, observing that the case exposes a broader failure of the state and society to protect vulnerable families from hunger and extreme poverty.

Granting bail to Lakhiben Solanki, who has been in custody since her arrest in March, Justice Hasmukh D. Suthar last week said the incident should not be viewed solely as an individual crime but as a reflection of systemic shortcomings in ensuring access to basic necessities such as food, healthcare and dignity.

According to the prosecution, Ms. Solanki allegedly assaulted her daughter, Eesha, after the child repeatedly asked for food.

In its order, the court said social justice rests on the principle that every individual is entitled to basic needs, including food and shelter. It observed that when starvation pushes a mother to such an extreme, the failure extends beyond the individual to society as a whole.

The court said the incident underscored shortcomings in social welfare mechanisms and highlighted the constitutional responsibility of the state to safeguard the nutrition, health and welfare of children and other vulnerable sections. Describing the case as a reminder that hunger is not merely an economic issue but one involving human dignity and justice, it said the tragedy should prompt greater compassion and renewed efforts to ensure that no mother or child suffers because of starvation.

Laggards among States need hand-holding, says Sitharaman

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In a renewed push for the idea of federalism, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday said India needs every State to be "strong", and that "laggard" States need to be given "every hand-holding" so they can improve.

At the same time, the country also needs a strong Centre to manage defence, exports and manufacturing, which a few States cannot take care of for the whole country, she added.

"I strongly believe States have to be strong," she said in response to a question on Centre-State relations.

"I strongly believe States have to be helped. I also strongly believe laggards among States will have to be told that you cannot be a laggard. Many times, we hesitate to say the fact, but they have to be pulled up." Ms. Sitharaman, who



Nirmala Sitharaman

was speaking at the India Policy Forum 2026 organised by the National Council of Applied Economic Research, said, "It cannot be that some States can do well and some others can remain where they are... We have to give them every hand-holding to get them to be back."

'Not sufficient'

However, the Finance Minister said that strong States themselves are not sufficient for the country.

"You also need a Centre which has the resources to take care of the defence of this country, which takes

care of having a policy which will enable exports, which will enable manufacturing," she said.

"It cannot be left to the States, and a 'beggar your neighbour' policy to get the industries and the investment."

Ms. Sitharaman said the country needs a Centre that can set "all the clear tones" to get investments and policies and ensure that parts of this country that have remained underdeveloped for a long time are helped to catch up with the rest of the country.

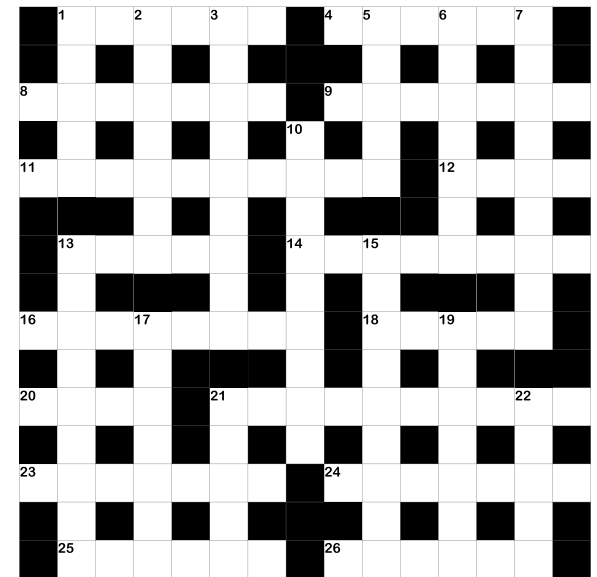
"So, there is a role for the Centre, and that role cannot be played by one or two States," she said.

"But yet, unless the States, and I mean each one of them, are empowered and given the resources and also given thoughts about how capacity can be built, the aspirations of India cannot be met," the Finance Minister added.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14866 (set by Gridzilla)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- 12. Returning from Yugoslavia too? (4)
- 13. Article describes origins of rheumatic orofacial pain (5)
- 14. Spooner's principal gets some sweet treats (8)
- 16. Laws, say, broken by trade union at the onset of strike (8)
- 18. Say, like a car, out of gas (5)
- 20. City is beautiful, and kept unpolluted for starters (4)
- 21. His beneficiaries are always late? (10)
- 23. An enclosed space over and alongside houses (7)
- 24. Bit of wine on the countertop? (7)
- 25. One fleeing from dreadful regime (6)
- 26. Tense day in an American company (2,4)

DOWN

- 1. Draft is correctly read out (5)
- 2. It goes fast, up and down? (4,3)
- 3. Order food containing good source of nutrition (9)
- 5. To see this spot, used a telescope (5)
- 6. Humanitarian aid nicely covers UP state (7)
- 7. What a groundskeeper requires is sold around corner (5,4)
- 10. How to get ideas pitched? (4,5)
- 13. Tea is served often in private meeting (4-1-4)
- 15. A time for one perhaps to take a little nap! (9)
- 17. Setter's opening tactic primarily overturned a disaster (7)
- 19. Like some nuts, dates, or bananas? (7)
- 21. Milk supplier from old city has daughters back in Kozhikode (5)
- 22. In retrospect, greed or envy (vices) destroy slowly (5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Five principles for liberation

The Five Principles, called *Artha Panchakam*, are the core teachings that every seeker of liberation should know. Sri Desika Srinivasa Thathachariar said in a discourse that understanding them is necessary before a person can receive initiation into the *Rahasya Trayam*, the three sacred secrets, from a spiritual teacher known as Acharya. As seekers move towards liberation, the Acharya offers guidance.

The first principle is *Para Svarupa*, the nature of the Supreme Being. Sriman Narayana is the Supreme Brahman. He is eternal, unchanging, and the very embodiment of knowledge (*jnana*). He alone is the ultimate cause, sustainer, and ruler of the entire universe.

The second principle, *Jiva Svarupa*, addresses the nature of the individual soul. The soul is distinct from the body, mind, and senses. Its essential nature is to serve as the eternal servant (*sesha*) of the Lord. The third principle is *Upaya Svarupa*, the essential nature of the means to attain the Supreme Lord. The way to liberation includes *Siddhopyaya*, the already achieved means consisting of the Lord Himself, and *Sadhyopaya*, the means the seeker should practice, such as Bhakti Yoga or Prapatti (Saranagati).

The fourth principle is *Phala Svarupa*, which describes the ultimate goal. When a soul is liberated, it goes to Sri Vaikuntha, leaves behind its subtle body, regains eight divine qualities, and enjoys the happiness of serving the Lord forever in His divine home. The fifth and final principle is *Virodhi Svarupa*, the nature of obstacles that prevent liberation. By understanding these five principles under the guidance of an Acharya, a seeker progresses towards moksha and service at lotus feet of Lord Vishnu.

INBRIEF



LIC Q1 net at ₹13,492 cr. up 23% on premium, business

Life Insurance Corporation of India's (LIC's) standalone net profit for the June quarter rose 22.81% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹13,492 crore on higher premium income and a surge in value of new business (VNB). Total premium income of the State-owned insurer increased 6.75% YoY to ₹1,27,250 crore. CEO and MD R.Doraiswamy said despite increasing competition in life insurance, LIC was able to maintain leadership in individual and group business during the quarter.

Milky Mist Dairy IPO opens on Aug. 11 at ₹133-140/share

Milky Mist Dairy Food Ltd. set price band of ₹133-140/share for its ₹1,553-crore initial public offering (IPO) opening for subscription on August 11. The IPO comprises fresh issue of equity shares aggregating up to ₹1,428 crore and an Offer For Sale (OFS) of up to ₹125 crore. K. Rathnam, CEO, told *The Hindu* a part of the IPO funds would go towards closing debt and the rest investments. Singapore sovereign fund Temasek invested ₹482 crore in the firm in May, taking a 5% stake.

Lumina Datamatics acquires 100% stake of TNQTech

Lumina Datamatics which is into content, retail support and technology solutions, said it acquired 100% stake in TNQTech, a Chennai-based publishing technology firm. In 2024, the company signed a pact to buy 80% stake in TNQTech. Mariam Ram, founder and director, TNQTech, said,“Our technology and domain expertise align perfectly with their scale and reach in scholarly publishing.”

July auto retail sales surged 26% to almost 26 lakh units

Lalathendu Mishra
MUMBAI

In July, Indian automobile industry retailed 25,91,138 units, up 26% year-on-year, making it the strongest July growth in the series outside COVID-distorted base years, said Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA).

Growth was broad-based with wheeled construction equipment sales up 46%, two-wheelers (2W) up 28.2%, tractors 28.1%, commercial vehicles (CV) up 24%, passenger vehicles (PV) 19.13% and three-wheelers (3W) up 16.2% as per FADA data. Total EV retail sales touched 3,27,901 units – the highest for any month



Commercial Vehicle retails at 99,666 units grew 24%. REUTERS

in history – with 2W and CV EV volumes at a record, taking overall EV growth rate to about 12.7% from 9.6% a year ago. Sai Giridhar, VP, FADA said, “July etched itself into Indian auto retail history – for the first time on record, every single category post-

ed its best-ever July with two- and three-wheelers, CVs, PVs, tractors and wheeled construction equipment all at all-time July highs.

GST 2.0 momentum “Dealers attribute this moment to GST 2.0-led affordability, ease of retail finance and favourable festival timing on a July 2025 base that had slid almost 4%, alongside a quiet inflection that deserves the industry’s attention: alternative fuels are now within striking distance of petrol in the PV market,” he said. “With FY27’s first four months EV retail sales up 18.27%, the runway into the festive season is firmly intact,” he added.

Taxation bill passed in the Lok Sabha

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Taxation and other Laws (Amendment) Bill, through which the government wants to promote domestic electronics manufacturing, attract foreign funds and modify the zero-MDR framework on digital payments was passed by the Lok Sabha.

The intention of the government behind bringing the Bill is to make India a more attractive and predictable place for global capital, manufacturing and business to come and stay.

The Taxation and other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, replaces the June 5 Ordinance that provided I-T exemption to interest income and capital gains made by FPIs from invest-



The bill would allow merchant charges on UPI transactions.

ments in G-Secs.

The Bill proposes to remove the linkage between the Payment and Settlement Systems Act and the Income Tax Act and give a legal backing to the government to modify the zero-MDR framework on UPI and RuPay card transactions. The move could allow merchant charges on select UPI transactions.

Sugar mills to advance cane crushing schedule

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

Sugar mills will start operating 10-15 days before the normal schedule for the 2026-2027 sugar marketing season to ensure adequate availability of sugar during the festival season.

At a meeting held with the Joint Secretary (Sugar) last month, the Indian Sugar and Bio-energy Manufacturers Association and the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories committed the mills will advance the sugarcane crushing schedule.

“This proactive decision will enable fresh sugar to reach the local market well ahead of the festive season,” the associations said.

Govt. okays ₹23,371 cr. GOBARdhan scheme

The National Circular Bioenergy Scheme aspires to raise local production of CBG by tenfold, mobilise private investments on a large scale

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Union cabinet approved the National Circular Bioenergy Scheme - GO-BARDhan, provisioning ₹23,731-crore to catalyse the growth of compressed biogas (CBG).

The GOBARDhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) outlay, to be in place until FY2035-36 seeks to raise local compressed biogas production almost tenfold via assured offtake, administered pricing, capital subsidies, boosting pipeline infrastructure and easier access to finance, the Centre said.

The government emphasised the scheme would seek to impart a “strong and predictable framework” to fuel the uptick of the CBG ecosystem.



Energy security: The compressed biogas plant at Brahmapuram currently processes about 50 tonne of biodegradable waste a day.

The programme would involve the use of agricultural residue, cattle dung, sugar industry waste such as press mud, municipal organic waste and other biomass to produce compressed biogas, which can be blended into CNG used in automobiles and also piped natural gas (PNG).

Three imperatives

Welcoming the government initiative, A.R. Shuk-

la, President of the Indian Biogas Association said the scheme addresses three imperatives – remunerative price, assured offtake and capital support – sought by the industry.

“This scheme delivers all three,” he said, adding, “moving from 300 operating plants towards 5,000 [plants] will create lakhs of rural jobs. Industry must respond with speed, quality and discipline.”

‘Oil cargoes from Russian Black Sea ports down two-thirds’

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

The Ukraine-Russia conflict has led to a 66% cut in India-bound oil cargoes from Russian Black Sea ports in the last two weeks, said Bimco, a leading shipowners association. Though Russia’s Baltic ports have the major share of India’s crude imports

from Russia, Black Sea ports provide some 30% of Russian imports. In June, over 50% of India’s crude imports came from Russia. Ukraine’s Black Sea attacks were concentrated around the CPC Novorossiysk terminal that supplied 0.7 million barrels/day to India in June. India’s oil import need is 5 million barrels/day. “Crude supplies

are secured till month end. If the situation persists beyond August, India will have to find alternative sources,” said Pankaj Srivastava, SVP, Rystad. Meanwhile, at least five Indian seafarers have been killed in ship attacks in Black Sea in July presumably from attacks by both belligerents. Two from a July 25 incident are still re-

RBI tags Tata Sons NBFC-UL, pressure mounts for listing

Lalathendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) released a list of 17 large (upper layer or UL) non-banking finance companies (NBFCs), which included Tata Sons subjecting them to enhanced regulatory norms for at least five years and mandatory listing within three years of identification.

The banking regulator released the list of NBFCs, which have been categorised as Upper Layer NBFC (NBFC-UL) for the year 2026-27 even as it said the status of Tata Sons would depend on its de-registration application outcome.

“The inclusion of Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd. in the list of NBFC-ULs is without prejudice to the outcome of its application for de-registration, which is under examination,” the RBI said.

It means Tata Sons, categorised as a core investment company, must adhere to the strict guidelines of the RBI and get listed.



RBI released the list of NBFCs categorised as Upper Layer.

Last year, following repeated demands for its listing as per RBI norms, Tata Sons applied for de-registration of its NBFC licence. However, the RBI is yet to approve the same.

The central bank’s framework categorises NBFCs in Base Layer (NBFC-BL), Middle Layer (NBFC-ML), Upper Layer (NBFC-UL) and Top Layer (NBFC-TL) and provides the criteria to identify the NBFCs in the Upper Layer.

The Shapoorji Pallonji Group which has 18% stake in Tata Sons, had been demanding the listing to re-

lease the capital blocked in the Tata Group holding entity. About 66% of Tata Sons is owned by charitable trusts and many Tata Trusts trustees reportedly supported it’s listing.

Other companies

Other companies that figure in the list are REC Ltd, Power Finance Corporation Ltd., Indian Railways Finance Corporation Ltd, Bajaj Finance, Shriram Finance, Tata Capital, LIC Housing Finance, Cholamandalam Investment & Finance, Muthoot Finance, Aditya Birla Capital, Housing & Urban Development Corporation, Mahindra Financial Services, L&T Finance, Bajaj Housing Finance, HDB Financial Services and Piramal Finance. All of these are listed except for Tata Sons.

As per the RBI’s framework of Scale Based Regulation, the UL would comprise NBFCs specifically identified annually by it as warranting enhanced regulatory requirements.

ported missing.

India has year-to-date been the single largest destination from Black Sea ports, receiving 25% of the exports from Russian ports in the Black Sea and Sea of Azov, according to Bimco.

On July 6, Ukraine unveiled Operation MoLoCh-Ka, a large-scale maritime drone campaign starting with Russia-linked ship-

ping in the Sea of Azov. Ukraine says it is aimed at disrupting Russian oil, fuel and cargo logistics. “Initially, the campaign reportedly targeted smaller ships operating from Sea of Azov ports and expanded to the Black Sea on July 15. By July 28, Ukraine claimed over 200 ships had been attacked,” says Niels Rasmusen, Bimco’s chief shipping

analyst. Ukraine’s drone operation hit Sea of Azov shipments and reportedly contributed to Russia suspending navigation via Kerch Strait and Don-Azov Canal, impacting exports. Oil loadings from the Caspian Pipeline Consortium terminal in Novorossiysk fell 62% in past two weeks compared with the previous four weeks, he says.

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE
Bangalore - 560012

IISc/CCMD/Tenders/2026-27 **Date: 04.08.2026**

Tender Notification- IISc/ Tender-ELE-04/2026-27

Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialised firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD/ railways/ MES/ central PSUs/ or any Government department of **Class I/Class A Electrical Contractors** are eligible to apply for the work of **“SITC of 6-passenger Elevator in Electrical Engineering Department in IISc, Bangalore”**. Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs. 20,37,052.00**. Last date of receipt of application is **24th August 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in **Sd/-, Registrar**

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE
Bangalore - 560012

IISc/CCMD/Tenders/2026-27 **Date: 05.08.2026**

Tender Notification- IISc/ Tender-AMC-1/2026-27

Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialised firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD/ railways/ MES/ central PSUs/ or any Government department are eligible to apply for the work of **“Renovation and retrofitting of 2*500 KLD sewage treatment plants and 1*100 KLD Effluent Treatment plant with two years Annual Maintenance Contract at IISc, Bangalore.”** Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs. 3,71,82,873.00**. Last date of receipt of application is **25th August 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in **Sd/-, Registrar**

Government of Kerala
Published Tenders from 03-08-2026 to 05-08-2026

Stationery Department

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864241_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Multilayered Board 58 cm x 78 cm x 200 GSM * Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs49997506

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864279_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Maplitho Paper 75 gsm RA1 * Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs24750000

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864307_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Maplitho Paper 75 gsm 86 cm reel * Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs47768000

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864031_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Maplitho Paper 83 cm Reel, 70 GSM * Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs644924203

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864160_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Maplitho Paper 41.5 cm Reel, 70 GSM * Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs30275029

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864170_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Maplitho Paper 76 cm Reel, 70 GSM * Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs266473977

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864190_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Maplitho Paper 83 cm Reel, 70 gsm * Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs16272025

Tender ID: 2026_STY_864232_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Multilayered Board 58 cm x 86 cm x 200 GSM * Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 * PAC: Rs95550541

Visit <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> for more details.

Ro.No:03-05/Aug/2026/PRD/(N)/7

GOVERNMENT OF GOA
DIRECTORATE OF TRIBAL WELFARE, PROJECT CELL, PATTO - PANAJIM, GOA.

e-TENDER NOTICE

No. GTWD(Project Cell)/F.08/2026-27/05 Dated: - 05/08/2026

This office has published above e-Tender Notices. The details are available on (Website: <https://eprocure.goa.gov.in>). The last date and time for online application for issue & submission of Tender Bid is 26/08/2026 up to 17:00 hrs. Detailed tender notices may be seen on the notice board of this office. For any Further Clarification, The Project Cell of this office may be contacted.

DI/ADVT/1122/2026

CENTRE FOR DEVELOPMENT OF IMAGING TECHNOLOGY (C-DIT)
Thiruvananthapuram-27
Ph: 0471-2380910/912

E-TENDER NOTICE

e-Tenders are invited for the Supply of “Aluminum Metalized Tamper Evident Polyester Film”.

Tender id: 2026_CDT_864482_1

For details and online submission of bid please visit www.etenders.kerala.gov.in

Last date of submission of bids: 13.08.2026, 03.00 PM.

06.08.2026 Registrar, C-DIT

दिल्ली प्रौद्योगिकी विश्वविद्यालय
DELHI TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
Established by Govt. of Delhi vide Act 6 of 2009
(Formerly Delhi College of Engineering)
SHAHBAD DAULATPUR, BAWANA ROAD, DELHI-110042

File No. F.DTU/Rect./T&P/2025/F-988/5363 Dated: 28/07/2026

ADVERTISEMENT NOTICE No. 02/2026

RECRUITMENT TO THE POST OF ASSISTANT PROFESSOR OF PRACTICE (TRAINING & PLACEMENT) AND PROFESSOR OF PRACTICE (TRAINING & PLACEMENT) on Tenure Track Appointment basis (for a maximum 05 years term)

The opening date and closing date for receipt of applications are as under:-

Opening Date for Submission of Online Applications	- 07/08/2026 (7 th August, 2026) from 11:00 AM
Closing Date for Submission of Online Applications	- 07/09/2026 (7 th September, 2026) till 05:00 PM
Closing Date for Submission of Hard Copy of Applications	- 21/09/2026 (21 st September, 2026) till 05:00 PM

Delhi Technological University is a teaching-cum-research University committed to foster excellence in education, research, technology incubation, product innovation, outreach and extension activities in Engineering, Management, and Applied Sciences. The University invites applications from the talented individuals to fill up the following posts on Tenure Track Appointment basis (for a maximum 05 years term):

Sr. No.	Nomenclature of Post	Classification of the post (Group)	Total No. of Posts* (Tenure Track Appointment basis)	Category
1.	Assistant Professor of Practice (Training & Placement)	Group A	01	UR
2.	Professor of Practice (Training & Placement)	Group A	01	UR

*The number of posts advertised is provisional and can be varied as per the requirement of the University. The interested candidates are required to fill up the online application form. After submitting the applications through **ONLINE**, candidates should take a printout of application form and submit it alongwith self-attested copies of certificates/documents to the Recruitment Cell, Room No. 801, 8th Floor, AB-3 Block, DTU, Delhi-110042. All further communications related to recruitment will be displayed on the university website www.dtu.ac.in from time to time. No personal communication will be entertained in this regard. The candidates are advised to visit the university website i.e. www.dtu.ac.in for detailed advertisement.

-Sd- Registrar

THE HUTTI GOLD MINES COMPANY LIMITED
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
Hutti - 584 115, Raichur Dist., Karnataka State. Phone: 08537-276339/275463
e-Mail: material276339@gmail.com website: www.huttigold.karnataka.gov.in

TENDER NOTIFICATION No.14/26-27 Dt: 07.08.2026
(Through KPP Portal only)

Tender is invited by “The I/c. Dy. General Manager (Materials)” for the following Tenders as detailed below

Sl. No.	Description	EMD in Rs.
1	Supply of Sodium Cyanide 98 Percent Purity. HGML/2026-27/IND0529	6,97,500/-
2	Supply of High Capacity Auxiliary Fan for Mechanized Development. HGML/2026-27/IND0534	1,68,000/-
3	Supply, Laying of Geotextile Coir Mat with Planting & Maintenance of Greenery on Slope of Tailing Dump at Hutti Gold Mine. HGML/2026-27/OW/WORK_INDENT144	2,31,000/-

Calendar of Events: (1) Pre-Bid Meetings (Zoom): 17.08.2026 for **Sl.No.1** at 11.00 AM, for **Sl.No.2** at 11.30 AM & for **Sl.No.3** at 12.00 PM
(2) Last date for receipt of tender: 07.09.2026 at 04.00 PM
(3) Opening of Technical Bid on: 09.09.2026 at 10.00 AM

For further details interested bidders are advised to log on to website <https://www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in> or contact the office of undersigned during working hours. For participating in the above tender bidder needs to be registered in KPP Portal.

Sd/- I/c. Dy. General Manager (Materials)

LEADING GOLD PRODUCER IN INDIA

WASHINGTON

Trump rejects munitions shortage report, says U.S. has ‘huge amounts’



President Donald Trump said on Thursday the United States has a vast supply of munitions and threatened those who suggested otherwise with jail terms as his frustration with the Iran war boiled over. The Republican leader lashed out on his Truth Social platform at media reports about the dwindling weapons stockpile. AFP

CAIRO

Houthi rebel attacks kill at least 30 Yemeni govt. forces, say officials



Attacks by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels on Thursday in central and eastern Yemen killed at least 30 government troops and wounded at least 50 others, Yemeni government officials said. A Houthi leader said Saudi-backed troops were targeted in the attacks and that “hundreds” were either killed or injured. AP

BEIRUT

Rights groups decry Israeli killing of Lebanon reporter as ‘war crime’



Rights groups said on Thursday that an Israeli attack in south Lebanon that killed reporter Amal Khalil and wounded another journalist earlier this year was an apparent “war crime”. The attack took place in the village of Al-Tiri on April 22, days after a ceasefire was announced between Israel and militant group Hezbollah. AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. sanctions Cuban Armed Forces Minister, five state-owned entities



The U.S. announced new sanctions on Thursday that target Cuban Armed Forces Minister General Alvaro Lopez Miera, seven others and five state-owned entities for “foreign military cooperation and arms procurement”. Earlier, UN experts had warned that U.S. sanctions risked pushing the island nation into “full-blown crisis”. AFP

‘Proposed deal will give Tehran control over inbound strait traffic’

Under the proposal, Tehran will be able to intervene if necessary with any inbound traffic in the strait, while outbound traffic will follow a route between Iran and Oman, with exit clearance granted through Muscat after notifying Iran

Reuters
LONDON

A proposed deal between Iran and Oman that would give Tehran control over ships entering the Gulf through the Strait of Hormuz is not easily workable due to U.S. sanctions and restrictive insurance clauses on any payments, four industry sources said.

Under the latest proposal, Tehran would be able to intervene if necessary with any inbound traffic, while outbound traffic would follow a route between Iran and Oman, with exit clearance granted through Oman after notifying Iran, a senior Iranian



A small boat sails past cargo ships and other commercial vessels anchored in the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas in Iran. AP

source told *Reuters*.

The ability of merchant ships to navigate international waterways “safely, predictably and without unnecessary impediment is fundamental to resilient

supply chains, economic stability and energy security”, the world’s leading shipping associations said in an open letter this week.

Introducing compulsory charges through the

strait for transit or service fees was “a toll in all but name”, the letter said, which was sent to the UN’s shipping agency.

What is known as a two-way traffic separation scheme was adopted by the UN’s shipping agency in 1968 with the agreement of countries in the region. It created the current ship routing system that split sailing corridors through Iranian and Omani waters. Iran is seeking fees of between 5% and 7% of the price of cargoes from ships using the strait. Oman is discussing fees of around 3%.

For shipping companies and oil traders, any imposition of fees creates major

compliance issues given the U.S. has imposed sanctions on the Persian Gulf Strait Authority, which Iran set up in May to operate the waterway. The U.S. Treasury has also prohibited U.S. persons from receiving services from Iran’s government related to a “guarantee of safe passage”. Any payment could lead to asset freezes, the industry sources said.

A further complication is the introduction in late July by Lloyd’s Market Association of a clause for use by war underwriters that terminates insurance cover for a vessel if it has paid a transit fee for passage through the Strait of Hormuz.

Ukraine strikes Russian oil refineries far from frontline

Agence France-Presse
MOSCOW

Ukraine struck two Russian oil refineries hundreds of kilometres from the border in an overnight attack, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Thursday, as Russia hit a train station and commercial ship in Ukraine.

Both sides have been intensifying their long-range attacks in recent months, leading to a jump in civilian deaths.

Kyiv has been firing record numbers of drones at Russia, while Moscow has been launching all-time high missile attacks.

Mr. Zelenskyy said Ukraine had hit oil refineries in the Bashkortostan and Yaroslavl regions – about 1,300 and 700 km from the front. The attacks were “strengthening the pros-



Smoke rises after a Ukrainian drone attack on an oil refinery, as per the regional governor, in Yaroslavl region of Russia. REUTERS

pects for diplomacy”, Mr. Zelenskyy said.

“Russia must choose peace,” he added, posting a video from Russian social media of black smoke rising above an oil facility.

Russia’s Defence Ministry said earlier it had downed 605 Ukrainian drones in the night.

Russian missile attacks on Kyiv a day earlier had

killed at least 17 and destroyed warehouses belonging to a number of retailers in what was widely seen as a direct response to Ukraine’s campaign targeting Wildberries.

Kyiv was unable to down any of the missiles Russia fired, prompting urgent calls from Mr. Zelenskyy for air defence supplies.

Bangladesh to hold presidential election on August 20, says EC

Press Trust of India
DHAKA

Bangladesh’s presidential election will be held on August 20, the Election Commission announced on Thursday, two weeks after President Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned on health grounds before completing his five-year term. Mr. Shahabuddin, 76, was a long-time ally of deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina.

“Chief Election Commissioner AMM Nasir Uddin has finalised the dates in consultation with [acting parliamentary] Speaker Kayser Kamal,” the EC’s senior secretary Akhtar



Akhtar Ahmed told presspersons.

Nomination papers will be accepted at the office of the Chief Election Commissioner on August 13. The scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on August 16. The last date for withdrawal of candidature is August 18.

International media need NOCs to report outside Pak’s cities

Agence France-Presse
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan’s government has instructed international media to register presspersons and seek permission for any reporting outside the country’s three main cities, sparking concern from rights and media groups over a threat to press freedom.

The Information Ministry sent a statement on Monday to an international media message group on the requirement to seek permission for reporting outside Islamabad, Lahore and Karachi.

Written guidelines published by the Ministry

stated all presspersons working for international media, including freelance reporters, should register with the government’s external media wing.

Organisations would then need to seek Non Objection Certificates (NOCs) from the government for reporting outside the three cities. It was not clear how widely the guidelines would be enforced or if penalties would apply for non-compliance. Local media and rights groups called for the requirements to be withdrawn.

Pakistan is ranked 153 out of 180 nations for press freedom in a Reporters Without Borders index.

China-Japan row escalates after Tokyo terms Beijing ‘greatest strategic challenge’

Press Trust of India
BEIJING

China has lodged a “serious diplomatic” protest with Japan over its latest defence white paper, which portrayed Beijing as Tokyo’s “greatest strategic challenge” and made “brazen comments” on Taiwan, further escalating tensions between the two countries.

“The white paper once again targeted China with groundless accusations, rehashing the so-called ‘China threat’ and grossly interfering in China’s internal affairs with brazen comments on China’s Taiwan region,” Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jing said on Wednesday.

“We deplore and firmly reject this, and have lodged serious representations with Japan,” he said while answering questions over Japan’s new defence white paper.

‘Internal affair’

Defending recurring military drills around Taiwan, which China claims as part of its territory, Mr. Lin said, “Taiwan is an inalienable part of China’s territory. The Taiwan question is entirely China’s internal affair. How to resolve it is a matter for the Chinese ourselves and Japan is in no place to interfere.”

About disputed islands in the East China Sea, he said, “Diaoyu Dao and its affiliated islands have been



Shinjiro Koizumi

China’s territory since ancient times.”

The islands, called Senkaku by Japan and Diaoyu Dao by China, are controlled by Tokyo. The Chinese coast guard periodically conducts patrols around them to assert Beijing’s sovereignty.

The white paper approved by Japan’s Cabinet

on Tuesday said China’s growing military actions are Japan’s top security challenge and “must be addressed through overall national strength and cooperation with allies and like-minded nations”.

The nearly 600-page white paper contained a detailed assessment of the increasingly volatile regional security environment.

In his preface to the white paper, Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi hoped that it would “deepen the public’s understanding of Japan’s defence and security, and serve as an opportunity for people to reflect on how security is linked to the future of every citizen”.

The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Sankaramangalam, Kollam-691 583
Phone: 0476-2651215 to 2651217, e-mail: md@kmmcl.com, URL: www.kmmcl.com

TENDER NOTICE
For more details, please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmmcl.com

Sl No.	Tender ID	Items
1	2026_KMML_864071_1	Tender for Stack Gas and Ambient Air Monitoring

Chavara 06.08.2026 Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

TAMIL NADU NEWSPRINT AND PAPERS LIMITED
Unit-1: Kagitthapuram – 639 136, Karur Dist. Tamil Nadu
Unit-2: Mondipatti – 621 306, Trichy District, Tamil Nadu

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Tender No	Description	Due Date
262713 002992	Procurement of Fuel Oil for Unit-I & II	20.08.26
262713 003030	Procurement of 180GSM Kraft Reels of various sizes for Unit-I & II	20.08.26
262723 001948	Procurement of LUBRICANT for Board Machine (CCK) of TNPL Unit-II	21.08.26
262723 001949	Procurement of AKD for Liquid Packaging Grade (ALU) for Board Machine (CCK) of TNPL Unit-II	31.08.26

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website and NIC Portal only. Detailed Terms & conditions are available in tender document at our websites: www.tnpl.com / www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgepp/app DIPR/2451/Tender/2026

BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer, K. R Pura Division,
Old Madras road, K.R.Pura, Bengaluru-560036
No: BECC/EE/KRP/TEND/04/2026-27 Date: 05-08-2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION (IFT) (TWO COVER SYSTEM)

The Executive Engineer, K. R. Pura Division, BECC, invites tenders on behalf of the Commissioner, BECC, Bengaluru from eligible Tenderers for the construction works detailed in the table below.

Sl No.	Name of the works
1.	Asphalting of Roads at SBI Colony, K V layout, Club Road and Surrounding Areas in Ward No-91 KR Pura (CAT-II (A) Reserve). Amount put to tender : ₹.70.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹.70,000/-
2.	Asphalting of Roads at Bosco Nagara 5th Cross, Papanna Layout and Surrounding Areas in Ward No-91 KR Pura. Amount put to tender : ₹.95.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹.1,90,000/-
3.	Ashalting of Roads and Improvements of Drains at Bethal Nagara, Munisawappa Layout, Muneshwara Layout, SV Layout, Domanic Layout, Ashwini Layout, Gayathri Layout, Priyadarshini Layout and Surrounding Area in Ward No-92 Basavanapura. Amount put to tender : ₹.165.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹.2,47,500/-

Calender of Events : (1) Last date for submission for queries on **14-08-2026 at 3:00 pm.** (2) Date and Time for Pre-Bid Meeting on **14-08-2026 at 3:30 pm.** (3) Last Date and Time for Submission of Tenders on **20-08-2026 at 4:00 pm.** (4) Date and Time for Opening of Technical Bid is **21-08-2026 at 4:30 pm** (5) Date and Time for Opening of Financial Bid is **24-08-2026 at 4:00 pm.**
Sd/- Executive Engineer
KR Pura Division, BECC

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE
Bangalore - 560012

IISc/CCMD/Tenders/2026-27 Date: 04.08.2026

Tender Notification- IISc/ Tender-CIV-06/2026-27

Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialized firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD / railways / MES / central PSUs / or any Government department of **Class I/Class A Civil Contractors** are eligible to apply for the work of “**Painting, Waterproofing & Miscellaneous works of Ramanujan hostels (Hostel No. 01 to 28), IISc**”. Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs. 36,96,447.00**. Last date of receipt of application is **24th August 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail office.cmd@iisc.ac.in Sd/-, Registrar

DEPARTMENT OF WOMEN AND CHILD DEVELOPMENT
Office of the Director, Dept. of Women and Child Development
PWD Building, Anand Rao Circle, Bengaluru - 560 009

No: WCD/ICDS/PSY/2/2025 Date:06-08-2026

TENDER SCHEDULE (PRE SCHOOL KIT FOR FY:2025-26 ANGANAWADI CENTRES)

Department of Women and Child Development hereby invites tenders from officially registered and eligible suppliers for the supply of **Pre School Kit to 69922 ANGANAWADI Centres** in the State of Karnataka for the year 2025-26. Interested bidders shall submit the bids through Government of Karnataka's Karnataka Public Procurement portal (<https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>).

1	Tender Reference No.	DWCD/2026-27/IND0112 Dated: 06-08-2026
2	Date of Commencement of Download of Tender Document from e-Procurement website: https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in	From:- 07-08-2026
3	Date, Time & Venue of Pre- bid Meeting	11-08-2026 Director office, Department of Women and Child Development, Anand Rao Circle, Bengaluru-560009, Karnataka.
4	Last Date and Time for uploading Online Queries in Karnataka Public Procurement portal	14-08-2026 up to 5:00 pm
5	Last Date and Time for uploading Tender in Karnataka Public Procurement portal	07-09-2026 up to 5:00 pm
6	Tentative Date and Time of Online Opening of Technical Bids	09-09-2026 @ 10:00 am
7	Tentatively fixed date for opening of financial bid after verification of documents Submitted in technical bid Date and Time	10-09-2026 @ 11:00 am
8	Place of opening of Tenders	Karnataka Public Procurement portal
9	Address for Communication	Office of the Director, Department of Women and Child Development, Anand Rao Circle, Bengaluru-560009 Karnataka, Phone:080-22353776 Email: directorwcd01@gmail.com jointdirector02@gmail.com

Sd/- Director, Dept. of Women and Child Development, Bengaluru
DIPR/CP/2029/CCL/2026-27

PREDICTION

Buttler believes Sooryavanshi will break his all-time T20 runs record



GETTY IMAGES

It's really cool, actually, to think you've got the most T20 runs out of anyone. Someone will surpass it one day — and his name's probably [Vaibhav] Sooryavanshi — England star Jos Buttler who surpassed Kieron Pollard to become the leading run-getter (14,833 to 14,803) in T20 history on Wednesday.

FRESH CHALLENGE

Forlan appointed head coach of Uruguay national team



FILE PHOTO

Diego Forlan has been appointed head coach of the Uruguay national team. He will take over from Marcelo Bielsa who stepped down following Uruguay's group-stage exit from the World Cup. "Forlan will take charge of the under-20 national team and the senior national team," the country's football association said.

BREAKING THE BANK

Real Madrid signs Ivorian winger Diomande in a record deal



AFF

Real Madrid on Thursday announced the signing of 19-year-old Ivory Coast winger Yan Diomande from Leipzig for what Spanish media reported was a club-record fee of €140 million euros including bonuses. *Los Blancos* said in a statement that "Diomande is tied to our club for the next seven seasons, until June 30, 2033".

STAKING CLAIM

Spain confident it will get to host the 2030 FIFA World Cup final



GETTY IMAGES

The Spanish government remained confident the final of the 2030 World Cup will be held in the country. Speaking after a report that FIFA allegedly awarded the final to co-host Morocco, sports minister Milagros Tolon said Spain "deserved" to host the summit clash. "We are the reigning men's and women's World champions," Tolon said.

Indian batters hope to come out on top in the spin test

The three-day practice match against Sri Lanka XI offers a chance for the visiting side to get a feel of the conditions in the island; however, rain threat looms over the contest in Colombo and may jeopardise the plans of Gill & Co.

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

Press Trust of India
COLOMBO

Indian batters will be keen to fine-tune their skills against spin during a three-day warm-up match against Sri Lanka XI at the Nondescripts Cricket Club here on Friday as they gear up for a two-match Test series against the Islanders next week.

Quality spin proved to be India's Achilles Heel against New Zealand and South Africa at home in the last couple of years, and the challenge will not be any different in Sri Lanka.

The Lankans have a capable unit of tweakers, particularly in home conditions, and thus this practice game assumes massive importance for the Indian batters ahead of the first Test at Galle on August 15.

Some frontline batters like skipper Shubman Gill,



Vital cog: Rahul's experience of having played Tests in Sri Lanka should stand him in good stead. x@BCCI

K.L. Rahul and Yashasvi Jaiswal had started preparations against spin individually at their home facilities before boarding the flight to Colombo, but that cannot really supplant an outing on a Sri Lankan pitch.

The outing will give them valuable first-hand idea about local conditions, and it is important because many of them are playing the red-ball format for the first time on these shores.

India's last Test series in

Sri Lanka was in 2017, and the team composition has undergone vast changes in the last decade.

In fact, among the current squad only Rahul, Kuldeep Yadav and Ravindra Jadeja have appeared in Test matches in Sri Lanka.

In the absence of an injured Jasprit Bumrah, pacer Mohammed Siraj will be the bowling spearhead with support coming from Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain.

Raring to go

Both Gurnoor and Saransh had very good outings for India-A against Sri Lanka-A last month at Galle, and they will be raring to have another round of practice under their belt.

However, intermittent rain is predicted to lash the city from Friday and that may jeopardise India's plans.

Meanwhile, Sri Lanka also announced a strong XI that contained some front-runners to make it to the Test squad.

Led by Sonal Dinusha, who has played three Tests, the squad features pacers Vishwa Fernando, Lahiru Kumara and spinners Isitha Wijesundara and Ramesh Mendis.

Come 15th morning, we will be ready: Gambhir

Press Trust of India
COLOMBO

Their home Test run in recent past may not have been particularly impressive but India head coach Gautam Gambhir has asserted that his team will be ready with all the answers when the two-match series against Sri Lanka gets underway here from August 15.

New faces

In a short address to the team before a practice session here, Gambhir also welcomed the new entrants — spin-bowling all-rounder Saransh Jain and pacer Aujib Nabi.

"We know what's in front of us, we know what we are playing for. We can do the volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes," Gambhir said in the video shared by the Board of control for Cricket in India on social media.

"Come 15th morning (August 15), whether we are batting first, whether we are bowling first, we're absolutely ready with every answer, every question that's thrown at us, and every



Consistent performer: Pacer Aujib has made it to the Test squad on the basis of his Ranji exploits. x@BCCI

answer we are ready to give. So make sure we tick all the boxes from now on."

Back in action

The first match will be played in Galle while the second game will be held here from August 23. It would be India's first ICC World Test Championship assignment since the disastrous 0-2 home defeat to

South Africa last November.

Saransh has been picked in the squad on the basis of his consistently fine run for Madhya Pradesh on the domestic circuit. Aujib is in to replace an injured Jasprit Bumrah. He played a stellar role in Jammu & Kashmir's maiden title-winning run in Ranji Trophy last season.

Tanvi enters Korea Masters last eight

BADMINTON

ANI
ASAN (KOREA)

Taipei Open champion Tanvi Sharma continued her impressive form by defeating compatriot Shriyanshi Valishetty 21-16, 17-21, 21-13 to reach the women's singles quarterfinals at the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament here on Thursday.

Ashmita Chaliha and Rakshitha Ramraj also advanced to the last eight.

In doubles, the men's duo of Krishna Prasad Garaga and Pruthvi Krishnamurthy Roy got the better of the Korean combination of Kim Young Hyuk and Shin Tae Yang 21-18, 21-19 to make the last eight.

The results (round of 16):

Women: Tanvi Sharma bt Shriyanshi Valishetty 21-16, 17-21, 21-13; Ashmita Chaliha bt Kim Min-ji (Kor) 21-17, 21-6; Rakshitha Ramraj bt Manami Suizu (Jpn) 22-20, 21-10; Kim Min-sun (Kor) bt Isharani Baruah 21-17, 21-18; Vu Thi Trang (Vie) bt Anmol Kharb 23-21, 15-21, 21-18; Han Qian Xi (Chn) bt Mansi Singh 21-12, 14-21, 21-17.

Doubles: Sumire Nakade & Miyu Takahashi (Jpn) bt Sonali Singh & Ritika Thaker 21-15, 21-9.

Men: Doubles: Krishna Prasad Garaga & Pruthvi Krishnamurthy Roy bt Kim Young Hyuk & Shin Tae Yang (Kor) 21-18, 21-19.

Mixed doubles: Shin Tae Yang & Kim Yu Jung (Kor) bt Ishaan Bhatnagar & Shruti Mishra 21-16, 16-21, 21-13.

Indian women's team gets the top billing

CHESS OLYMPIAD

P.K. Ajith Kumar

The Indian women are seeded first in the Chess Olympiad, to be held from Samarkand from September 15 to 28. The men are seeded second, behind the top seed United States. India is the reigning champion in both sections.

Koneru Humpy, Divya Deshmukh, R. Vaishali, Vantika Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri make the women's team, while in the open section — women are free to compete with men in chess — D. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi, Nihal Sarin and Vidit Gujrathi will defend the crown.

The men's team shows one change, with P. Harik-

rishna being replaced by Nihal.

And there are two changes in the women's team, with Humpy and Savitha coming in for D. Harika and Tania Sachdev.

Formidable outfits

In the open section, the United States, which features top players like Fabiano Caruana, Wesley So and Levon Aronian, host and third seed Uzbekistan, which includes Javokhir Sindarov, Nodirbek Abdusattorov and Nodirbek Yakubboev, China, Germany, and the Netherlands are among the stronger teams in the open category. The USA's average rating is 2751, while India's is 2733.

In the women's section, India would be challenged by the likes of second seed Georgia, Kazakhstan, Chi-

na — which isn't fielding some of its best players, — Ukraine and the United States.

The average rating of the top-seeded India is 2476, while Georgia is 2449.

The 46th edition of the Olympiad, the equivalent of the Davis Cup in tennis, has attracted a record 400 teams — 208 in the Open and 192 in the women's sections. At Budapest in 2024, there were 380 teams.

The Olympiad will be played over 11 rounds and games will be contested over four boards. The best players in each section are also awarded individual board medals.

In the last Olympiad, Gukesh, Arjun, Divya and Vantika had won individual gold medals for India.



In focus: Gukesh's form will be vital for India's chances in the Open event while Vaishali is expected to pull her weight for the defending champion in the women's section. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Newcastle's talent exodus: are the Magpies becoming a feeder club?



Seeking better opportunities: Gordon and Tonalì have completed big money moves to other clubs while Guimaraes is close to sealing his. REUTERS & AFP

FOOTBALL

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

Newcastle United's ambitious project to reign supreme over the Premier League kingdom is collapsing like a poorly built sandcastle.

The Magpies are losing world-class talent left, right, and centre, evidently moving farther away from realising CEO David Hopkinson's target of putting Newcastle "in the debate about being the top club in the world" by 2030.

In the 2026-27 summer transfer window, Newcastle has sold winger Anthony Gordon (to Barcelona for almost €80 million), midfielder Sandro Tonali (Tottenham Hotspur, approximately €108 million), and has all but lost captain Bruno Guimaraes to champion Arsenal.

The exodus is not limited to the players, as head

coach Eddie Howe, too, stepped down from his role last Friday, less than a month before the start of the season.

The English manager — who won the club its first domestic trophy in 70 years (2025 Carabao Cup) — decided to move on, seemingly frustrated by the club's inability to retain its top players.

Baffling play

While feeder clubs have historically made a successful business out of selling their finest talent to the 'big boys' for big bucks, a team of Newcastle's stature resorting to this transfer strategy is perplexing.

Even after considering the club's compulsions to comply with the sport's financial regulations, the underlying trend of football's heavyweight names not wanting to stay or sign for Newcastle cannot be overlooked.

Last year's Alexander

Isak transfer saga will be a grim reminder for the club, which is backed by the financial might of Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund.

The incomings at St. James' Park have been more out of hope than expectation, with the club buying youngsters who are yet to perform consistently at the highest level.

The likes of Sean Steur (18 years old), Bazoumana Toure, and Aladji Bamba (20) are fine outfield prospects to have, but are hardly ready to anchor a squad hollowed out by elite departures.

Shattered team

It is this shattered team that new head coach Matthias Jaissle is inheriting.

Can the German gaffer make some prudent signings in the remainder of the window and build a team worthy of the Newcastle colours?

Vinicius to stay at Real until 2032

Reuters
MADRID

Real Madrid has secured the future of Brazilian winger Vinicius Jr., extending his contract until June 2032, the Spanish giant announced on Thursday and bringing an end to months of speculation over his future.

The 26-year-old Brazil international has been a central figure in Real's attack in recent seasons and had been linked with a move to English champion Arsenal. His previous contract was due to expire in June 2027.

"Real Madrid and Vinicius Jr. have agreed to extend our player's contract, which now keeps him with the club through June 30, 2032..." Real said in a statement.

"Vinicius has become one of the most important players during one of the most successful periods in our history."

Vinicius has scored 128 goals and registered 100 assists for Real.



Vinicius Jr. AFP

From World champions to a side in panic mode

Post the IPL, Indian cricket has been grabbed by a sense of despair and dismay. The bubble emphatically burst in Ireland when, against all odds and in an upset of gargantuan proportions, the home side stunned the Men in Blue 2-0 in a T20I series; the Sri Lanka tour will be a big test of Gill's batsmanship and his man-management skills



GETTY IMAGES

R. Kaushik

It's only been five months since India successfully defended their T20 World Cup crown in Ahmedabad. It's been five long months since Suryakumar Yadav's men became the first outfit to triumph on home soil.

The euphoria of a grand campaign which climaxed in two powerhouse batting displays that netted team totals in excess of 250 in both the semifinals and the final disappeared in less than three weeks as the IPL carnival marched into town and pitched tent. The exploits of a 15-year-old quickly relegated the World Cup heroics to a footnote, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi setting the world afire with one spectacular knock after another to break down the doors to international cricket.

However, post the IPL, Indian cricket has been grabbed by a sense of despair and dismay. The bubble emphatically burst in Ireland towards the end of June when, against all odds and in an upset of gargantuan proportions, the home side stunned India 2-0 in a Twenty20 International series. India were at full strength, under a new captain with Suryakumar having been given the heave-ho because of a poor run of scores that couldn't make up for his wonderful leadership abilities at the World Cup. Yet, the Irish breezed past Shreyas Iyer's side in the first game and held their nerve to eke out a one-run victory in the next, triggering euphoria in the little nation and disbelief and shock elsewhere in the world. India had an immediate chance to make amends in England against the team that had run them perilously close in the World Cup semifinal. But with Harry Brook firing on all cylinders and his colleagues taking their cue from the skipper, England stormed to a 4-0 victory (the first match was washed out) to ensure there was no joy on the snappy tour of the United Kingdom for the new leadership group of Shreyas and head coach Gautam Gambhir.

Some redemption

The only salve came in the form of a 3-0 sweep in Zimbabwe when V.V.S. Laxman stood in as head coach. After Ireland, nothing was a formality anymore and therefore those who might point out that there was nothing flash about the 'expected' outcome might want to think again. India were back to their dominant selves, almost, in the three fixtures at the Harare Sports Club to briefly dispel the pall of gloom. But as they embark on their latest challenge in the World Test Championship, the picture of a ship in trouble, with the crew disjointed and pulling in different directions when the need of the hour is to stay on the same page and resuscitate a challenge now floundering desperately, is discouraging, at the very least.

The list of injuries has mounted alarmingly in the last few weeks. It was bad enough that all-rounders Washington Sundar and Nitish Kumar Reddy, as well as Harshit Rana, the pacer whom Gambhir is trying to shape into an all-rounder, were ruled out of the

two-Test tour of Sri Lanka long before the selectors under Ajit Agarkar met to pick the squad. Among those selected was Jasprit Bumrah, the pace king who is the best bowler in the world, his tribulations in the IPL notwithstanding, and who can take the pitch and the conditions out of the equation anywhere in the universe. Subject to the caveat that he needed to clear a fitness test at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, a caveat that also accompanied left-handed batter Sai Sudharsan's selection.

Bumrah has since been ruled out, yet to fully recover from the impact injury to his left knee sustained while fielding in the second One-Day International against England in Cardiff some three weeks back. It's a bitter blow because there is no greater gamechanger in world cricket than the man from Ahmedabad with a quirky walk/run-up and action.

Often, Bumrah's presence creates the pressure that allows bowlers operating from the other end to garner wickets - that's when Bumrah himself isn't cutting a swathe through the opposition batting. Without him, India's chances of extending their winning streak in Sri Lanka have taken that much of a beating, necessitating the other bowlers to step up and share the burden so that Shubman Gill isn't left wondering who to turn to - in every sense of the term - for the breakthroughs so crucial to winning Test matches.

Injury management has become a massive bone of contention, with a convenient accusatory finger pointed at the CoE, a soft target when the actual 'culprits', for want of a better word, are more firmly entrenched within the contours of the national side and whose task it is to monitor the fitness and recovery from injury of those who are playing international cricket on a reasonably regular basis.

In the last few days, rumours that Agarkar's tenure as chief selector might come to an end in the next month or so have gained traction. Insiders say the former India paceman had indicated to the Board of Control for Cricket in India as early as in February that he would like to be relieved of his responsibilities in September, though there is no clarity of any nature on why so when he still has a couple of years of the maximum permissible five to serve out. Agarkar took over as the chairman of the senior selection panel in the middle of 2023 and his stint has seen some grand highs and several debilitating lows, some of them alongside Gambhir and others independent of the latter, when Rahul Dravid was the head coach.

Among the terrific accomplishments are two T20 World Cup trophy runs and an unbeaten charge through the draw at the Champions Trophy in Dubai in March 2005. The lows, notwithstanding the 6-0 T20I drubbing in Ireland and England, have largely come in Test cricket, and that too at home - 0-3 against New Zealand in October-November 2024, 0-2 against South Africa in November last year.

India have been hoist with their own petard, continuing to operate in the erroneous and misplaced conviction that they are still the best players of the

turning ball when the ground realities paint an entirely different picture.

Change of guard?

All of a sudden, CoE boss Laxman's name has cropped up as a potential successor to Agarkar, just as it had more than two years back when it was taken for granted that he would take over as the head coach of the national side from his friend Dravid. Laxman isn't coaching-averse - he wasn't in 2024 either - but perhaps having to spend so much time away from home didn't appeal to him. In a stand-in capacity, first for Dravid and more recently for Gambhir, he has done a stellar job. In so many ways, Laxman is a bit like Ravi Shastri, a man for a crisis. Laxman's reputation as a crisis man was firmly established during his playing days when he bailed the team out of a spot more than once, several of them with the bowlers - he has never liked the word 'tailenders' - for company. Whether Agarkar is actually contemplating stepping down and, in that eventuality, whether Laxman is the preferred and willing choice, remains to be seen. But it is clearly this artificial uncertainty that Indian cricket could do without as it approaches a crucial phase in the five-day game with nine Tests lined up in the next seven months, four of them away in Sri Lanka and New Zealand.

In some respects, it would seem as if the misadventures in the UK have forced a pressing of the panic button when the crying need is for calm heads and an acceptance that while the results didn't go according to plan, it doesn't mean the end of the world. India contributed to their misery in England, especially, choosing not to respect the conditions or the quality of the opposition bowling - Jofra Archer on tracks that have a bit in them is a far different proposition from Archer of Rajasthan Royals playing his wares on batting beauties in the IPL. Instead of embracing equanimity, there is, those in the team insist, a shrill insistence on outcomes, which can never be a positive development.

In strict confidence, some of the more established players have hinted at a feeling of insecurity because of the mixed messaging from the regular think-tank, which will be without two established names when the tour of Sri Lanka kicks off on Friday with a three-day First Class fixture. Assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate, who came on board nearly two years back when Gambhir took over from Dravid, and fielding coach T. Dileep, who has been with the national squad for a lot longer, are now surplus to requirement. How the players, already feeling the pinch after being pushed to a corner, adapt to this new normal, however temporary it might be, will determine how well they acquit themselves in a land where India are unbeaten in a Test series since 2010.

For Gill, this is a huge challenge, a big test of his batsmanship but also his man-management skills and his tactical awareness. With Bumrah only playing three of five Tests in England last

summer, Gill came through with flying colours on his maiden foray into Test captaincy. That he led from the front, with a mountain of runs (754), helped. After making elementary if understandable errors in his first couple of matches, Gill gradually grew into his role and was in complete command by the time of the last Test at the Oval, when he eked out match-winning and series-levelling performances from experienced pacer Mohammed Siraj and relative newcomer Prasidh Krishna. He led in only one of two Tests against South Africa, missing the huge rout (by a record 408 runs) in Guwahati with a neck injury, and therefore doesn't carry a great deal of baggage. But he himself hasn't played a Test in Sri Lanka - very few in his squad have, given that India's last five-day outing in the Emerald Isle was in 2017-and this will be India's first Tests since last November (not counting the one-off game against Afghanistan in New Chandigarh in June). India have their task cut out on the field, against a Sri Lankan side with so much riding on the outcome. Gill's lads will be well advised to ignore off-field distractions and focus on the personnel available rather than mope about those who aren't. Transition and inexperience will no longer cut ice. Few will know that better than Gambhir, feisty and combative but clearly aware that his CV is anything but impressive, let alone exemplary.



THE GIST

- ▼ The euphoria of a grand T20 World Cup campaign disappeared in less than three weeks as the IPL carnival marched into town and pitched tent
- ▼ Injury management has become a massive bone of contention, with a convenient accusatory finger pointed at the CoE
- ▼ It would seem as if the misadventures in the UK have forced a pressing of the panic button when the crying need is for calm heads

Growing your own food, time for leisure: what life is like in a blue zone

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Cabinet-approved cost of Guwahati-Tezpur NH-15 corridor

8,970 in ₹ crore. The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved the development of 135.871 km, 4-lane access-controlled Guwahati-Tezpur Corridor of NH-15 in Assam for ₹8,970.20 crore. The project will be developed on a build-operate-transfer (BOT) toll mode. PTI

Number of saplings to be monitored by digital system

23 in lakh. The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has launched a first-of-its-kind digital monitoring system to track its ongoing plantation drive in real time, with geo-tagged data, photographs and a public dashboard aimed at ensuring the survival of saplings, officials said on Thursday. PTI

Cabinet approved cost for GOBARdhan scheme

23,731 in ₹ crore. The Cabinet on Thursday approved a unified circular bioenergy scheme with an outlay of ₹23,731 crore to boost biogas production in the country. The GOBARdhan scheme will be implemented from 2026-27 to 2035-36. PTI

India's non-fossil fuel electricity generation capacity

300 in GW. India's non-fossil fuel electricity generation capacity has crossed 300 GW and the country is on track to achieve its target of 500 GW of renewable energy capacity by 2030, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Thursday. PTI

Iron ore resources in Gadadharpur block won by Coal India

258 in million tonnes. Coal India has won the Gadadharpur iron ore block in Odisha through a competitive auction, according to the State's director of mines and geology. The block contains 258 million tonnes of iron ore resources. REUTERS
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The Beijing model of innovation

Beijing's innovation model brings together universities, start-ups, industry and the state to turn research into commercially viable technologies by bridging the 'valley of death'; the ecosystem is driving China's push in AI and humanoid robotics through state-backed funding, talent and industrial clusters

WORLD INSIGHT

Ananth Krishnan

If the conventional wisdom about innovation is that it is best left to individuals and private enterprise – and the best thing a government can do is get out of the way – that is certainly not the thinking in Beijing.

How innovation happens in Beijing offers a snapshot into China's model in which research universities, start-ups, the market and the state all have a role to play.

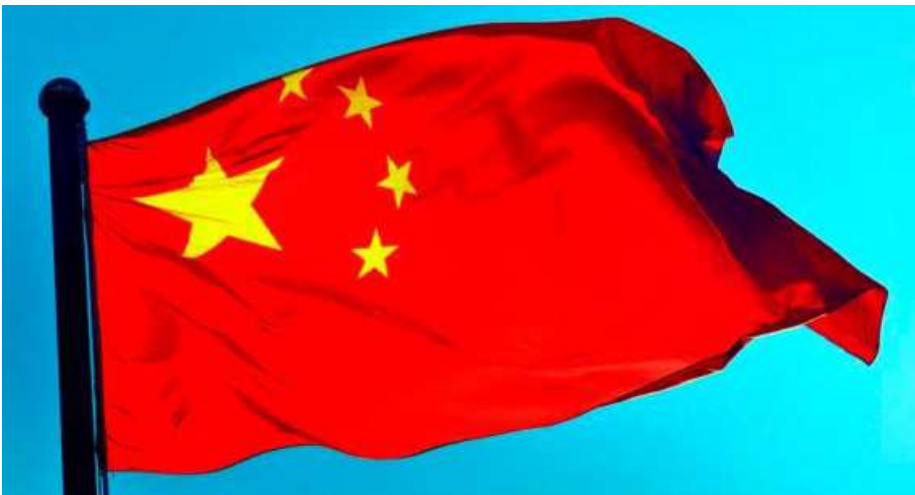
The Chinese capital has always had the country's most important cluster of research universities, with Peking University and Tsinghua leading the list. It is also home to several cutting-edge robotics and AI companies, including Moonshot, which was started by graduates of Tsinghua and made waves over its latest Kimi K3 open-source model.

"A closed loop from project discovery to incubation" is how Yang Xiuling, who as the Director General of the Beijing Municipal Commission of Development and Reform leads the city's top economic planning body, describes the ecosystem. "Our greatest strength," she says, "is talent and the concentration of top research universities."

The challenge that then follows is how to leverage that talent, or, as she puts it, "how to move results out of the lab". The gap between translating early research into commercially sustainable ventures is known as the "valley of death" for innovation. To cross that valley in Beijing, the state steps in.

Beijing's Zhongguancun research cluster is at the forefront of tech innovation in China, along with clusters in Shenzhen, Shanghai and Hangzhou. A strong undercurrent of competition underpins the national innovation ecosystem, especially when it comes to attracting and keeping talent.

To deal with the "valley of death", Beijing set up what it calls "an intelligent



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platform for results commercialisation" led by a group of tech managers, who, Ms. Yang says, "are a bridge because they understand both the tech and the market". In 2025, the city's platform executed 1.04 lakh tech contracts.

"Markets and companies are still at the centre," Ms. Yang says. "But the way we look at it is that the companies pose questions, and the universities can provide answers. The companies still play a key role in R&D and in taking the lead in collaborative research with institutions".

The universities provide the foundation from which the rest follows, says Zhang Jihong, who is a Director at the state-run Zhongguancun Science Park. "It's the universities that have helped incubate a number of high-tech enterprises," he says. "We have formed a virtuous cycle where the universities produce talent, the talent provides intellectual support for innovation, and innovation again reinforces the growth of universities."

The state as investor

The state's role here is twofold. It provides the hard infrastructure, as seen in the science park and a number of incubators littered around Zhongguancun.

More importantly, it also provides

capital, not only linking start-ups to private venture capital (VC) but also stepping in with state-backed capital to help bear some of the risk.

The state taking a direct stake in companies is a unique feature of this ecosystem. The upside is it helps bear losses and allows for the longer-term, patient kind of support that VC might not afford. This has played a key role in enabling the speed and scale of innovation in China.

The downside is wasteful spending, if state funds do not do their due diligence, which is often the case. So much so that this has emerged as a growing concern for Chinese regulators, who in June issued new rules to tighten how local governments spend these funds.

The intense competition among different clusters, coupled with the collapse in land sales as a source of revenue for local governments, has led to a splurge in spending at the local level, with each province putting in funds with the hope of finding its national champions, even if they lack the capacity to do the needed due diligence. The new rules have now called for stricter control over how these funds are spent and for more approvals from the Central government.

Humanoids on the factory floor

AI and robotics are the twin peaks of Beijing's current innovation drive. If Zhongguancun in the north is the home of tech talent, the Yizhuang industrial cluster in the city's southern suburbs offers a snapshot of how innovation is playing out on the factory floor. Here, a hub-and-spokes model has the state's Humanoid Robot Innovation Centre at its centre, which funnels talent to a number of robotics companies around its periphery. "The idea," explains Che Zhengping, who is Head of Embodied AI at the Beijing Humanoid Robot Innovation Centre, "is to build a full supply chain that is ready for mass production". The current focus in humanoids is to "shift from industrial use scenarios to daily use scenarios", including healthcare, which is expected to be a major source of demand in an ageing society.

Among the companies in Yizhuang is Lingyi iTech, which in April started production on humanoid robots and is already planning to scale up. "Advancements in technology are making it more affordable" to scale, says Vice President Philip Yang. "As we move from semi automation to full automation," he estimates, "costs in 2030 will be half of what they are today."

Lingyi already has production capacity "for the next 5 to 6 years". By the end of 2027, it will be making 20,000 robots annually. The plan is to scale up to 1 lakh units by 2028 and 5 lakh by 2030 from this Yizhuang facility (the company has four others), by when it hopes to be "one of the world's top three".

At the state-run innovation centre next door, researchers pore over unfinished humanoid robots, getting them to perfect a range of delicate movements before the latest model is given the green light.

State subsidies of land, policy and tax support are among the more well-known elements of China's industrial policy. The state's enabling of talent and intellectual support are perhaps less well-known, but arguably just as important when it comes to getting innovation right.

THE GIST



Beijing's Zhongguancun and other innovation clusters are using research universities, technology managers and incubators to help move scientific results from laboratories into the market.



The city's push for AI and humanoid robots is being supported by industrial hubs, state-backed capital and policies aimed at building a full supply chain for mass production.

Why are households pledging gold instead of selling it?

How are rising prices reshaping India's traditional appetite for gold jewellery?

Santosh V. Perumal

The story so far:

For centuries, gold has had a prime position in India's economic and social landscape. Gold has proved its timeless appeal, but global uncertainties and their disruptions have led to a structural change in its holding pattern in India, exhibiting a dual-track economy, one steeped in tradition (as wedding and festival buying to provide seasonal support) and another shaped by modern portfolio management.

How is the demand pattern for gold changing?

India's overall gold demand was up 2% year-on-year (YoY) to 282 tonnes in the first half (H1) of this year, driven by investment demand as ETFs hit a record high; while jewellery demand declined 17.1% to 141.2 tonnes (also the second-lowest first quarter or Q1 on record since 2000), according to the

World Gold Council (WGC) data.

In the second quarter (Q2) alone, India's overall gold demand was down 6% YoY to 131.4 tonnes, with jewellery demand (30% of overall gold demand, the lowest since the WGC began tracking the data in 2000) falling faster at 15% to 75.1 tonnes, the second-lowest in Q2 since 2000. India was the world's largest gold jewellery market in the quarter, accounting for 27% of global demand, WGC data suggest.

Investment demand was seen softening in Q2 to 54 tonnes but was higher than the long-term quarterly average of 49 tonnes, hinting at above-average demand and pointing towards sustained investment interest.

Q1 was a record for Indian gold ETFs, with net demand of 20 tonnes, driven by strong investor participation amid elevated gold prices and subdued domestic financial markets. Similarly, bars and coins saw a 21.3% and 105.5% surge in volume and value, respectively, in H1FY27.

Is investment gold overtaking jewellery?

The shift in allegiance to investment instruments such as ETFs, gold bars, and coins is palpable as the price of the yellow metal increased more than fivefold in the last 10 years, against India's national average (economic growth), and is seen favourably from a current account perspective.

According to IIFL's Capital Outlook 2026, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), in 2025, stepped up gold purchases just as global gold prices rallied sharply.

The combination (household gold and the RBI purchases) helped cushion the impact of rupee depreciation and strengthened India's external balance at a time when foreign portfolio flows were under pressure, it said.

Affordability pressures pushed jewellery demand down. Yet, consumers' gold purchases hit a record ₹1.98 lakh crore, reflecting the extraordinary jump in prices.

The domestic MCX spot gold price was

broadly flat in Q2FY27, supported by the import duty hike and the rupee depreciation (down by 4% QoQ). Even with this quarterly moderation, the domestic prices remained substantially higher than a year earlier. To put it in perspective, 10 grams of gold jewellery bought in 2016 for about ₹28,000 and more than ₹89,000 in H1 last year would cost ₹1.5 lakh or more in 2026.

Given the scenario, jewellery's monopoly as the preferred form of ownership started slowly fading, while financial gold made inroads and gained legitimacy among urban and younger investors, who preferred gold bars, coins and ETFs, which are seen as better investment vehicles.

The rising popularity of investment gold comes amid a previous unsuccessful attempt by the government to encash it, although India has one of the world's largest private gold stocks.

The Gold Monetisation Scheme, introduced in 2015, was designed to mobilise idle household gold by allowing individuals and institutions to deposit gold with banks and earn interest. But was met with lacklustre performance due to taxation concerns and procedural complexities.

Why are households pledging gold instead of selling it?

The apparent contradiction in India's gold market – falling jewellery demand but rising investment appetite – is now accompanied by a third trend as

households increasingly use the existing gold holdings as collateral.

According to the WGC, outstanding retail bank loans backed by pledged gold jewellery reached around ₹4.3 lakh crore by February 2026, rising 124% YoY.

The broader banking system has also seen an extraordinary acceleration in gold-backed lending, with gold loan portfolios reaching about ₹5.4 lakh crore by June 2026, registering close to 94% YoY growth. Despite domestic gold prices being around 60% higher YoY, holders showed limited appetite to sell, preferring to monetise their gold holdings rather than liquidate them, keeping recycled supply "muted", according to WGC.

The rapid expansion of gold loans needs careful monitoring in view of financial vulnerabilities it can create.

The RBI strengthened its regulation to promote responsible lending, as it mandated borrowers to make full repayment of the principal and interest before repurchasing the asset.

What is next?

India's huge household gold stock can evolve from a passive store of wealth into an active financial asset, which could ease some of the traditional pressure that gold imports place on the current account.

Time is not too far for India's financial markets to see a better combination of monetisation schemes, financial innovation, recycling, market reforms and digital transparency for unlocking the huge pile of privately held gold.

